Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Acts

Acts 1:1–3

Here, Luke summarizes his first book, the Gospel of Luke, which he wrote for Theophilus. Luke also calls him "most excellent" (Luke 1:3). This title indicates that he was a person of very important social status (compare Acts 23:26; 24:2; 26:25). He was probably a financial donor or patron who helped Luke with the costs of publishing or distributing his work (see study note on Luke 1:3).

Acts 1:3

- He presented Himself to them with many convincing proofs that He was alive: The Gospels provide evidence for Christ's resurrection:
- Jesus's tomb was empty (Luke 24:3–4).
- No one disturbed his grave clothes (John 20:3–9).
- Many people saw him (see Matthew 28; Mark 16:1–8; Luke 24:1–53; John 20:11–21:23; 1 Corinthians 15:3–8).
- Jesus appeared to the apostles to help them overcome their doubt (Matthew 28:17; Luke 24:17–24, 38, 41; John 20:27; see Mark 16:14).
- the kingdom of God: This was the main theme of Jesus's teaching (see Acts 1:6–8; Matthew 4:17; Mark 1:14–15; Luke 4:43).

Acts 1:4

wait for the gift the Father promised: See 2:1–13; compare with John 14:15–17.

Acts 1:5

baptized: See "Baptism" Theme Note.

Acts 1:6–11

He was taken up: Jesus ascended into heaven (see also Luke 24:50–53). This happened on the Mount of Olives (Acts 1:12; Luke 24:50). This was the last physical appearance of Jesus. He ascended into heaven, where he will stay "until the time comes for the restoration of all things" (Acts 3:21).

Acts 1:8

- This key verse shows how the good news about Jesus extended from place to place:
- It began in Jerusalem and Judea (1:6–8:1).
- It then came to Samaria (8:4–25).
- Next, it went to Antioch in Syria (11:19–30).
- Later, it extended across the Mediterranean Sea to Rome (13:1–28:31).
- Christ gave a similar mission to Saul of Tarsus (9:15). At first, Saul was well-known for persecuting Jewish Christians. After his encounter with Christ, he became the main person spreading the gospel to non-Jews (Gentiles).
- when the Holy Spirit comes: The Holy Spirit provided the power for all these missionary efforts for the good news about Jesus.

Acts 1:10

as He was going: The ascension of Jesus into heaven shows his promotion to a position of ultimate authority (see Ephesians 1:19–23; Philippians 2:9–11).

Acts 1:11

in the same way: Jesus promised to return from heaven in the same way (see Matthew 24:30; Mark 13:26; John 14:3). Jesus has gone to heaven to prepare a place for his followers (John 12:26; 14:1–4; 2 Corinthians 5:4; Philippians 3:21; Hebrews 6:20).

Acts 1:12

Those who witnessed Christ going into heaven returned to Jerusalem with joy, worship, excitement, and praise to God (Luke 24:52). The angels' message eased their doubts (see study note on Acts 1:3).

Acts 1:13

All eleven of the remaining apostles were present (compare Matthew 10:2–4; Mark 3:16–19; Luke 6:13–16). Judas Iscariot is not on this list because he had already betrayed Jesus and killed himself (Acts 1:18–19).

Acts 1:13–26

The apostles waited for the promised gift of the Holy Spirit (1:4–5). All 120 disciples in Jerusalem were persisting in prayer (1:13–14). Then they chose a new apostle to replace Judas Iscariot (1:15–26).

Acts 1:14

- The first disciples came together for worship, fellowship, and prayer (see also 2:42, 46–47; 4:24–31; 5:12; 12:5; 13:1–3). The faithful women who witnessed Jesus's crucifixion and resurrection were there (Luke 23:49, 54–56; 24:1–10, 22).

- The brothers of Jesus did not believe in him during his earthly ministry (John 7:3–5; compare Matthew 12:46–49). But they became his disciples after his resurrection.

Acts 1:16–17

the Scripture had to be fulfilled: See 1:20.

Acts 1:18–19

The account in the Gospel of Matthew is slightly different (Matthew 27:3–10). We can match the two accounts by understanding the priests' purchase of the "Field of Blood" as if they acted on behalf of Judas. Also, Judas may have killed himself by hanging, but he later fell headfirst. Then his body split open, possibly when the rope broke.

Acts 1:20–21

May another take his position: It was extremely important to find someone to replace Judas so there would still be twelve apostles. The church was the new Israel so it needed twelve leaders chosen and appointed by God (see Matthew 19:28; Luke 22:29–30).

Acts 1:21–22

To qualify to be an apostle, a man needed to have been with the other apostles throughout the public ministry of Jesus. This period started from the time John baptized Jesus and continued until Jesus was taken up into heaven.

Acts 1:23–26

- With prayer and humble dependence on God that he would reveal his will, the apostles cast lots (1:14, 24). This was a traditional way to discover God's will (see Leviticus 16:8; Numbers 27:21; Deuteronomy 33:8; Joshua 14:2; 18:3–10; Proverbs 16:33). God chose Matthias by lot to replace Judas. After Pentecost, the Holy Spirit guided the followers of Jesus through dreams, visions, and prophecies instead of through lots (compare Acts 2:17–18; 13:2; 16:7–10).
- You know everyone's heart: See also 1 Samuel 16:6–7; 1 Kings 8:39; 1 Chronicles 28:9; 2 Chronicles 6:30; Psalms 7:9; 44:21; Jeremiah 11:20; John 2:24–25; Revelation 2:23.

Acts 2:1–4

Jews observed three traditional annual festivals. Many people traveled to the temple in Jerusalem for these feasts (see Leviticus 23:1–44):

- The Feast of Unleavened Bread (which includes Passover)
- The Feast of Weeks (also called Pentecost or the Feast of Harvest)
- The Feast of Tabernacles

On Pentecost, Jewish people gathered in Jerusalem to thank God for the harvest and his blessings. At the same time, the disciples of Jesus gathered together in prayer with shared hope. Then the Holy Spirit came and filled the believers who were present.

Acts 2:4

- And they were all filled with the Holy Spirit: This event marks when the Holy Spirit came down from heaven. He filled the disciples, as Jesus had promised, to empower them as witnesses of Christ's resurrection (1:4–5, 8). The Spirit's wisdom, energy, and power enabled the church's work and witness (for example, 2:14–41, 43; 4:31; 9:17, 20; 13:9–12; see also Ephesians 5:18).
- began to speak in other tongues: The Holy Spirit gave them the ability to communicate so people from other countries could hear about God's works in their own languages (Acts 2:6–11). This passage is one of several references to speaking in "other tongues" (see also 10:44–48; 19:6; 1 Corinthians 14:2–28, 39). This divine gift shows the energy of the presence of God's Spirit. This event marks the beginning of the gospel (the good news about Jesus) being announced to people from every nation.

Acts 2:5–11

Since Pentecost was a feast people had to travel to attend, Jews from every nation were in Jerusalem (see study note on 2:1–4). They could hear the gospel (the good news about Jesus) in their own languages. The gospel is for all people (2:38–39).

Acts 2:9–11

- The Parthians came from the region between the Tigris River and India.

The Medes, now known as Kurds, were from Media, located east of Mesopotamia and north of the Persian Gulf.
The Elamites were from Elam. This area is now in Iran, north of the Persian Gulf and just east of the Tigris River.
Mesopotamia was between the Tigris and Euphrates rivers.
Judea was well known as the Jewish homeland.
Cappadocia, Pontus, and Asia were Roman provinces in Asia Minor, now part of Turkey (see 1 Peter 1:1). The

apostle Paul later taught and preached in some of these areas (see Acts 16:6; 19:10, 26).
Phrygia and Pamphylia were districts in Asia Minor that Paul later visited (13:13; 18:23).
Egypt had a large Jewish population, especially in Alexandria (see 18:24).
North Africa included Libya and Cyrene.
Rome was the capital of the Roman Empire and home to thousands of Jews.
The Cretans were from the island of Crete, located south-southeast of Greece.
The Arabs were from the area south and east of Jerusalem.

- Including all of these nations demonstrates how God intended the gospel to reach the ends of the earth (1:8).

Acts 2:10–11

converts to Judaism: See study note on 13:43.

Acts 2:14–36

This is the first of about 30 speeches in Acts and one of the most important. It marks the beginning of the Christian church. It is a typical example of the preaching of the apostles.

The apostles proclaimed:

1. that the Old Testament promises came true in the life, death, and resurrection of Jesus, the promised Messiah;
2. that the apostles were eyewitnesses of the public ministry of Jesus and were his chosen representatives;
3. that people must turn away (repent) from their sins and trust in God through Christ; and
4. that salvation and the presence of the Holy Spirit are promised to those who have a positive response to this message of the gospel.

This basic message repeats in the sermons of chapters 3, 4, 5, 8, 10, and 13. The same themes characterized the apostle Paul's preaching (see 1 Corinthians 15:3–9). The apostles all repeated this message when preaching to both Jews and non-Jews (Gentiles) throughout the world around the Mediterranean Sea. All people must turn away (repent) from their sins and turn to God by trusting in Jesus Christ.

Acts 2:17–21

This passage quotes Joel 2:28–32. The prophet Joel prophesied that in the last days, many people would have the gifts of prophecy, including visions and dreams. This would include both young and old, and both men and women (Joel 2:28–29). In Acts, on the day of Pentecost, Peter announced that Joel's prophecy was coming true, indicating that "the last days" had begun.

Acts 2:23–28

Although cruel men put Jesus to death on a cross, they did not defeat God's plan for salvation. In fact, God raised Jesus from the dead, just as David had foretold (2:25–28).

Acts 2:27

abandon my soul to Hades: See the study note on Matthew 11:23.

Acts 2:32–36

God has raised this Jesus to life, to which we are all witnesses: The theme of witnessing repeats often in Acts (for example, 3:15; 4:33; 5:32; 10:39–43). The main point of this message is that God the Father, as he promised, is now pouring out his Holy Spirit on the church through the resurrected Jesus. All the people of Israel were called to recognize that God had acted with power. He made Jesus, whom they put to death on a cross, both Lord and Messiah!

Acts 2:34–35

This passage quotes Psalm 110:1, which Jesus fulfilled when he ascended (went up) into heaven (Acts 1:9).

Acts 2:37–38

Brothers, what shall we do?: Peter urged his listeners to repent of their sins, trust in God, and be baptized. See the "Baptism" Theme Note.

Acts 2:42

- fellowship: The Greek word koinōnia means a close relationship marked by sharing and participating in life together.
- and to prayer: At this stage, prayer probably included taking part in the formal prayers of the temple (see 3:1).

Acts 2:42–47

Luke makes a clear connection between personal faith and belonging to the Christian community. Life in this new community included:

- devotion to the teaching of the apostles from God's word,
- fellowship,
- sharing,

- joy, and
- praise.

As a result, the Lord continued to add to their number those who were being saved.

Acts 3:1–11

Jesus promised that his disciples would do greater works than he did (John 14:12; see Mark 16:20). This promise came true through the signs, wonders, and mighty works of the apostles (Acts 2:43; 5:12; 8:4–8).

The apostle Peter showed the power to heal in the name of Jesus Christ of Nazareth (3:6, 16). The healing was immediate and evident (3:8). It led the man to praise God (3:8–9; compare 2:47; 16:25; Luke 2:20; 17:15–18; 18:43; 19:37; 24:53). This event is the first of many displays of divine power given to the apostles in Acts (Acts 4:24–31; 5:12; 6:8; 8:6; 9:33–42; 28:8).

Acts 3:6

In the name of Jesus: Speaking the name of Jesus demonstrates who he is and his power to heal (see Mark 9:38–39).

Acts 3:10–11

- The Beautiful Gate was probably the Nicanor Gate, made of bronze from the city of Corinth. It was on the east side of the temple (see Josephus, War 5.5.3). It had rich decorations of silver and gold plates on its panels. The gold and silver were heavier and more valuable than the plates on other gates.
- Solomon's Colonnade was a covered place to walk on the east side of the temple (see Josephus, War 5.5.1–3; Antiquities 20.9.7).

Acts 3:12–26

The speeches in the book of Acts about telling others the good news focus on Jesus, who was put to death on a cross and raised to life. These speeches call people to repent and to place their faith in Jesus as the promised Messiah and the judge God has appointed (2:38; 3:19; 11:18; 17:30; 26:20). They also announce the same good news for the people of Israel and for Gentiles everywhere: there is "peace through Jesus Christ, who is Lord of all" (10:36).

Acts 3:15

Many Jewish people could not imagine that God himself, the author of life, could be killed. They did not recognize Jesus as the Messiah (compare 13:27; Luke 23:34). They also did not understand that the Messiah would be divine, that is, sharing God's nature (see John 1:1–18; compare Daniel 7:13–14).

Acts 3:17

- brothers: This was a common way to address each other (13:15, 26, 38; Genesis 27:29; Leviticus 10:6; 25:46; Numbers 20:3; Deuteronomy 1:28; 24:7; Joshua 22:3–4; 2 Samuel 2:26; Ezekiel 11:15).
- in ignorance: See Acts 17:30; 1 Timothy 1:12–14. The Christian message challenges this lack of knowledge. The gospel calls everyone to respond with faith and to repent (Acts 2:38).

Acts 3:19

Other sections of the book of Acts and the Gospel of Luke explain the good news of "forgiveness" in more detail (see Acts 5:30–32; 10:36–43; 13:26–38; Luke 24:25–27, 45–47).

Acts 3:19–21

The message of the good news about Jesus (the gospel) brings comfort (see Matthew 11:28–29). The second coming of Jesus will bring times of refreshing from God. He will send Jesus to his people again.

Acts 3:22

Jesus fulfills the ancient promise that God would raise up a prophet like Moses (see Deuteronomy 18:15, 18; compare John 6:14; 7:40).

Acts 3:23

Refusing to obey Jesus, who is God's ultimate prophet, will lead to severe consequences (John 3:16, 17, 36).

Acts 3:25

all the families of the earth will be blessed: God always intended the covenant people to share his blessings with the world, not for the Jews to be selfish and keep God's blessing only for themselves.

Acts 4:1

Sadducees: See "The Sadducees" Profile.

Acts 4:1–22

Throughout the Bible, God's people often experienced persecution. God's servants often encountered hostility and opposition (Deuteronomy 30:7; 1 Kings 18:13; Nehemiah 4:1–3; Jeremiah 37–38; Matthew 23:34–37; Luke 11:49–51; 1 Thessalonians 2:14–15). Jesus was also persecuted (Luke 4:29; John 5:16). He warned his disciples to expect similar treatment (Matthew 10:23; 24:9;

Mark 13:9; Luke 21:12; John 16:2). However, he promised that the Holy Spirit would provide them with strength (Acts 1:8; Luke 12:11–12; 21:15).

The book of Acts records many examples of persecution (Acts 4:3; 5:17–41; 7:54–8:3; 9:1–2; 11:19; 12:2; 13:50; 14:19; 16:19–24). But it also emphasizes that the Holy Spirit empowers apostles to testify in such situations (4:8–13; 6:10; 7:55). The courage of Peter and John before the hostile Jewish high council shows how Christians should face persecution with courage and power (4:20).

Acts 4:4

and the number of men grew to about five thousand: See study note on Matthew 14:21.

Acts 4:13

they were unschooled, ordinary men: This means they were not scholars or trained teachers of the Scriptures. Peter and John were working men without higher education.

The members of the Jewish high council were educated, and people saw them as authorities on the Scriptures and religious matters. Because of this, the council members were amazed to hear untrained men speak so boldly about these topics.

Acts 4:16–18

They acknowledged the miracle but still tried to prevent the message. Jesus had experienced similar resistance (Matthew 19:8; Mark 10:5; see also Deuteronomy 10:16; 30:6; Jeremiah 4:4).

Acts 4:19–20

The apostles shared a principle that can guide God's people in dealing with hostile authorities (see also 5:40; compare 1 Samuel 15:22; Jeremiah 7:23; Luke 20:20–26; Romans 13:1–7). Jesus had predicted that his disciples would encounter hostility and persecution (Luke 21:12–19).

Acts 4:23–31

The believers heard the report that their leaders had been threatened and commanded never again to speak about Jesus (4:18). The Christian movement was clearly under attack from the religious authorities, so they united in prayer. They turned to God, sharing their troubles and asking for courage to speak the message. They also asked God to send signs and wonders to confirm that the message was true. God answered their request in a clear and powerful way.

Acts 4:25–26

This passage quotes Psalm 2:1–2, which describes how the Gentile (non-Jewish) nations react to the Lord's anointed king. Similarly, the Jews and Gentiles in Jerusalem had gathered together against Jesus and now against his followers.

Acts 4:26

The Hebrew term Messiah (which means "anointed one") originally referred to Israel's anointed king. Later, it referred to the Messiah, God's chosen future king of Israel who would establish God's kingdom forever (2 Samuel 7:14–16; Psalm 89:36–37; Isaiah 9:6–7; 11:1–9; 61:1; Jeremiah 23:5–6; 33:14–16; Luke 1:32–33).

Acts 4:28

God had been guiding events to fulfill his purpose. The Old Testament also shows God's guidance in his people's lives (see Ezra 7:6, 9, 28; 8:18, 31; Nehemiah 2:8, 18; Ecclesiastes 9:1; Ezekiel 8:1; Romans 8:28; 1 Peter 5:6).

Acts 4:32–35

The sharing among the early believers was remarkable (see also 2:44–45; compare 6:1). They were united in heart and mind (they thought alike and shared the same purpose). They freely shared what they owned to meet the needs of other believers. This sharing was voluntary and not forced. It responded to real needs in the community and was motivated by Christian love and care for one another.

Acts 4:36–37

Barnabas is presented as an example of generous and unselfish giving in response to real needs in the Christian community.

Acts 5:1–11

Luke likes to balance a positive example with a negative one. He just shared the remarkable and positive story of Barnabas (4:36–37). Now, Luke shows the opposite behavior of Ananias and Sapphira. This couple desired to earn status in the community and for others to admire them. Ananias did not have to sell his property or give away the money. Their sin was pretending and dishonesty.

Acts 5:3–4

By lying about the sale of their land, Ananias was not just being dishonest towards others but also toward the Holy Spirit. This means he was lying to God. His actions harmed the honesty, unity, and integrity of

the church at its foundation. As a result, he experienced God's direct judgment (compare Leviticus 10:1–5; Joshua 7:16–26).

Acts 5:11

great fear came over the whole church and all who heard about these events: The sudden judgment on Ananias and Sapphira had a serious impact on both the Christian community and those who learned about it (see Hebrews 10:31). Christians were strongly reminded to remain pure.

For non-Christians, the integrity of Christians was restored. So once again "the people regarded them highly" (Acts 5:13). However, it also made those outside the church cautious about joining a group with such high standards (5:13). This divine "pruning" allowed for new growth to occur (see John 15:1–11; Acts 5:14; see also 6:5–7; 11:24; 21:20).

Acts 5:12–16

The preaching of the apostles included many miraculous signs and wonders, similar to the ministry of Jesus. There were also powerful acts of healing and casting out demons (see also 6:8; compare Matthew 4:24; 9:35; Mark 1:32–34; Luke 4:40–41).

Acts 5:13

- Although the people regarded them highly: People respected the believers because their way of life was different.
- no one else dared to join them: The people may have been afraid because of the high level of commitment expected of believers. They may also have feared what happened to Ananias and Sapphira (5:11).

Acts 5:17–40

The apostles' successful ministry caused strong opposition (compare 4:1–3). The wealthy and powerful Sadducees controlled the temple and had a temple police force. They opposed belief in the resurrection and were determined to challenge and, if possible, prevent the apostles from sharing their message about the resurrection of Jesus. They felt their influence over the Jewish people weakening. Jealousy and bitterness led them to attack the apostles.

Acts 5:19–20

The irony is that the Sadducees denied the existence of angels (23:8). However, angels appear many times in the book of Acts (see also 10:3, 7, 22; 11:13; 12:6–11, 23; 27:23–24). Luke shows God guiding his people in their ministry, using angels to carry out his purpose.

Acts 5:29

See study note on verses 4:19–20.

Acts 5:30–32

We are witnesses of these things: As witnesses, the apostles had the responsibility to speak about what they had seen and heard (see Leviticus 5:1; compare Acts 1:8; Matthew 28:18–20; Luke 24:44–49; John 20:21).

Acts 5:33–40

God once again stopped the plans of the Jewish leaders to silence the apostles. This time, he did so through the advice of Gamaliel.

Acts 5:34

Gamaliel was a respected Pharisee and a leading member of the Jewish high council. He was also a well-known teacher of the law. He later taught Paul during his training to become a Jewish rabbi (see 22:3).

Acts 5:36–37

- This Theudas is otherwise unknown, although the Jewish historian Josephus mentions a different man with the same name who led a revolution some years later (see Josephus, Antiquities 20.5.1). Theudas was a common Jewish name.
- Judas of Galilee appears in Josephus as a rebel who opposed paying taxes to Caesar around AD 6 or 7, following the census of Quirinius (see Josephus, Antiquities 20.5.2; compare Luke 2:2). His resistance was stopped by the Roman authorities, who used force to end the revolt

Acts 6:1

- the Grecian Jews: The Greek-speaking Christians were Jewish Christians from other parts of the Greek and Roman world. They likely followed some Greek customs. The Hebrew-speaking Christians were more traditional Jews from Palestine. They spoke Hebrew or Aramaic and avoided Greek customs.
- their widows were being overlooked: This injustice threatened the church's growth and development. Overlooking needs from one group caused frustration and required an intentional response to correct the behavior.

Acts 6:2–6

- The apostles showed wisdom by calling a meeting of all the Christians to resolve the dispute. They under-

stood that the problem was very serious. They also knew their priority was teaching God's word. They decided to choose men who were wise and filled with the Holy Spirit to manage the food distribution.

The community agreed with the plan the apostles proposed. They selected capable leaders from the Christians who spoke Greek (all of their names are Greek). These seven men focused on this special task, allowing the apostles to pray and teach.

- These seven men are sometimes called the first deacons because their role is similar to that of the office of deacon (see 1 Timothy 3:8–13). Although the Greek term translated "deacon" (Greek diakonos, "servant") is not used here, a related Greek word is translated "to wait on tables" (6:2; Greek diakonein, "to serve").

Acts 6:7

- The apostles were wise in how they dealt with the issue. This led to an increase in the number of Christians, including many of the Jewish priests.
- his is the first of three places in Acts where Luke notes that God's message continued to spread (see also 12:24; 19:20). When serious difficulties arose, God's message overcame internal conflict, idolatry, and pagan practices. As a result, the community continued to grow. The book of Acts tells the story of how the good news about Jesus spread without being stopped (see 28:31).

Acts 6:8–15

The Jewish leaders did to Stephen as they had done to Jesus (compare Matthew 26:3–4, 59–66):

- They found someone to lie about him,
- they accused him of blasphemy (saying offensive things about God),
- they started a riot,
- they arrested him, and
- they made false charges against him.

Acts 6:15

his face was like the face of an angel: This is similar to when the face of Moses "was radiant" after speaking with the Lord (6:14; see Exodus 34:32–35). Stephen, like Moses, was bringing God's instruction to Israel (see also 2 Corinthians 3:7–18).

Acts 7:1–53

- Stephen answered the accusations by speaking about his Lord (see Luke 21:12–17). Instead of defending himself, he became a witness in God's legal case against them. This revealed how contrary they were and their lack of loyalty. Stephen gave a history of Israel's past and reminded them of their repeated rejections of those who announced God's messages.
- Stephen's review of Israel's history has three main parts:

1. The work of the patriarchs. This refers to Abraham and those descended from him who founded the nation of Israel (Acts 7:2–16).
2. The ministry of Moses (7:17–43).
3. The role of the tabernacle and the temple (7:44–50).

Stephen ended his historical survey with a strong criticism of his people's lack of obedience. Like a prophet, he challenged them to stop resisting the Holy Spirit. He told them to turn to God with grief for their sins (repentance) and faith.

Acts 7:8

the covenant of circumcision: See Genesis 17:9–14. See also "Circumcision in the New Testament" Theme Note.

Acts 7:14

seventy-five: Compare this number with the seventy mentioned in the Hebrew text of Genesis 46:27. The number seventy-five probably comes from the Septuagint, the ancient Greek translation of the Old Testament. The Septuagint includes three people descended from Ephraim and two of Manasseh in 46:20. This adds five more people. The Hebrew text does not include those descended from Joseph's sons. New Testament authors mostly quote from the Septuagint, which sometimes differs from the Hebrew Masoretic Text.

Acts 7:16

a price: This was 400 pieces of silver, according to Genesis 23:16.

Acts 7:37

a prophet like me: This verse quotes Deuteronomy 18:15. Moses prophesied that the Messiah would come. It happened as Moses said.

Acts 7:39–40

The ancient Jews rejected the law Moses gave to them for their salvation. Stephen was speaking to the people of his time who were physical and spiritual descendants from those Jews. His point was that they were still rejecting God's messengers. In this case, it was Jesus, the ultimate savior.

Acts 7:42–43

This passage quotes Amos 5:25–27 (Greek version) to show how the people of Israel rebelled against Moses (Acts 7:39–41).

Molech was a Canaanite god to whom human sacrifices were offered (Leviticus 18:21; 20:2–5; 1 Kings 11:7; 2 Kings 23:10; Jeremiah 32:35).

Rephan, a star god identified with the planet Saturn, was worshiped by the Israelites during their wilderness wanderings.

Acts 7:48–50

One charge against Stephen was that he spoke against the temple (see 6:14). The leading priests and scribes managed the temple's business and wanted to protect their interests (see Luke 19:45–48). This is why these leaders were concerned about the temple, even though God said that the Most High does not live in temples made by human hands.

Acts 7:51

Stephen accused the people of being stiff-necked with uncircumcised hearts and ears. This means they were strong-willed and ignored God's truth. This was exactly how God had accused them of behaving during the time of wilderness wandering. Here, Stephen links it to rejecting the gospel and resisting the Holy Spirit (see Exodus 32:9; 33:3; 34:9; Deuteronomy 9:6, 13; 31:27; see also Psalm 78:8; Zechariah 7:11–12).

Acts 7:55–56

- standing at the right hand of God: Usually, the Bible describes Jesus as seated in heaven at God's right side (2:33–34; 5:31; Luke 20:42; 22:69; Romans 8:34; Ephesians 1:20; Colossians 3:1; Hebrews 1:3, 13; 10:12). One possible explanation has been proposed by some church fathers that Jesus was welcoming Stephen to heaven with honor as the first New Testament martyr. Stephen was loyal in confessing his Lord on earth. Now his Lord honored his promise to confess his loyal servant in heaven. Jesus was standing as a witness to defend him (Matthew 10:32; Luke 12:8).
- Son of Man standing: Compare Daniel 7:13–14. The Jewish leaders understood that Stephen was speaking of Jesus as the divine Son of Man (Acts 7:57). This title speaks of Jesus's power and authority (compare Revelation 1:12–15).

Acts 7:57

They covered their ears because they thought comparing Jesus to the divine Son of Man was a terrible offense against God (7:56).

Acts 7:58

Saul was his name in Hebrew, and Paul was his Greek name (see 13:9).

Acts 7:59–60

Stephen's prayer, "Lord, do not hold this sin against them," is very similar to the prayer Jesus prayed when he was on the cross (Luke 23:34). Jesus taught his followers the importance of forgiveness and prayer (Matthew 6:14–15; Mark 11:25; see Luke 11:4; 17:3–4; Luke 11:5–10; 18:1–8; see also Acts 1:12–15; 4:23–31; 12:5; James 5:16–18). The Lord gave a positive answer to Stephen's prayer as it relates to Saul (Acts 9:1–43).

Acts 8:1–4

Saul was there: Compare 9:1–2; 22:4; 26:9–11; Galatians 1:13–14. This major attack against the church caused all believers except the apostles to flee. Instead of losing enthusiasm, they preached the good news about Jesus wherever they went.

Acts 8:7

Came out ... healed: Miracles often happen when the gospel is preached in the book of Acts (see study note on 3:1–11).

Acts 8:9–24

Simon the sorcerer performed magic and amazed the people of Samaria. He boasted that he was someone great. Simon tried to buy spiritual power. The later corrupt practice of buying and selling positions of leadership in the church was called simony. This term refers to the corrupt practice of buying and selling church leadership positions (see 1 Timothy 6:9–10). Peter strongly criticized Simon's evil intentions and actions.

Acts 8:14–17

When the apostles sent two of their own representatives to Samaria, it was an important step in overcoming prejudice (compare Matthew 10:5; Luke 9:52–54; John 4:9; 8:48). It was even more remarkable that Peter and John prayed for the Samaritans who trusted in Christ to receive the Holy Spirit. This event is similar to the day of Pentecost in Jerusalem and marks how the Holy Spirit's power spread from Judea to Samaria (Acts 2:1–47; 1:8).

Acts 8:24

Simon recognized that he needed Peter to pray for him. However, the text does not clearly say that Simon repented or turned away from his evil actions. His request seems focused on avoiding the severe punishment Peter warned about, rather than on a true change in how he thought and acted.

Acts 8:26–40

Philip obeyed the Holy Spirit and followed the Spirit's direction. He then took the opportunity to share the message of the gospel with an Ethiopian eunuch (a trusted male official who served a king or queen) on the desert road from Jerusalem to Gaza. This event shows how effective Philip was in explaining and sharing the Christian message. It also shows his strong commitment to bringing the good news to all people, no matter their social position or ethnic background.

Acts 8:27

- In the ancient world, a eunuch was a royal official. Some eunuchs had been physically altered and could not have children, while others held the title because of their role in the royal court (see 2 Kings 9:30–32; Esther 1:10; 2:3, 14–15, 21; 4:4–5).

Many Jews looked down on eunuchs. Eunuchs could not have children, so they could not pass on the covenant family line (God's people through descendants). The law of Moses also excluded men with damaged genitals from the assembly of Israel, which was the gathered worshiping community (Deuteronomy 23:1; compare Leviticus 21:17–23).
However, the prophet Isaiah spoke of a future time when God would welcome non-Jewish people and eunuchs who were faithful to him (Isaiah 56:3–8; see also Matthew 19:12). In the new covenant, all people who have genuine faith belong to the people of God.

- The eunuch traveled from Africa to Jerusalem to worship in the temple, probably for a major Jewish feast.

Acts 8:29

The Holy Spirit guides the servants of God in where, when, and what to preach, teach, or do (Acts 9:15; 10:19–20; 11:12; 16:6; 1 Corinthians 2:13; 1 Peter 1:12).

Acts 8:32–33

The Scripture passage was Isaiah 53:7–8. It is one of the Servant Songs of Isaiah, a passage that speaks of the suffering servant of the Lord.

Acts 8:39–40

- After the Spirit of the Lord carried Philip away, he traveled north along the coast from Azotus. Azotus is another name for Ashdod (see 1 Samuel 5:1–7; Nehemiah 13:23–24; Isaiah 20:1). He preached in every town until he reached Caesarea, where he later settled (see Acts 21:8).
- Caesarea: Caesarea Maritima was a major port on the Mediterranean Sea. It was the center of Roman government in Judea. Herod the Great built it around 22 to 9 BC and named it to honor Caesar Augustus, the Roman emperor.

Acts 9:1–19

The conversion of Saul of Tarsus on the Damascus road is central to the story in Acts. Luke tells the story three times (also 22:1–21; 26:1–29). Paul (Saul) mentions this experience several times in his letters (1 Corinthians 15:8–10; Galatians 1:11–17; Philippians 3:4–11; see 1 Timothy 1:12–17). Saul's conversion was his call as a prophet and commission as an apostle (Acts 9:15; 22:15, 21; 26:15–18). No one is beyond God's power to reach, save, and use for holy purposes. Nothing is impossible with God (Luke 1:37). God prepared Paul through his training, childhood, and experience to play a unique role in proclaiming the gospel to the wider world as the "apostle to the Gentiles" (Romans 11:13; see 1 Corinthians 15:9; 2 Corinthians 12:11–12; Galatians 1:1; Ephesians 3:8).

Acts 9:2

- A synagogue (Greek sunagōgē, meaning "gathering place") was a local Jewish meeting place. After the exile to Babylon, Jewish people began to meet in synagogues in their towns. These places became centers for teaching and worship. After Israel returned from exile in Babylon, Jews began using synagogues for instruction and worship.

In the synagogue, people read from the Law and the Prophets. Leaders explained the meaning of the Scriptures. The people also prayed and gave praise and thanks to God (see 13:15; 15:21; Nehemiah 9:5; Matthew 6:5; Luke 4:16–21). Jesus attended, taught, preached, and performed miracles in synagogues (Matthew 12:9–10; Mark 1:21, 39; Luke 4:16; 13:10–13; John 6:59; 18:20). His apostles did as well (see Acts 9:20; 13:5, 14; 14:1; 17:1, 10, 17; 18:4, 19, 26).

- Damascus: Damascus, the capital of Syria, was an important center with a long history. It was the nearest major city outside of Palestine. It took four to six days to travel from Jerusalem to Damascus.

This emphasizes Saul's determination (9:1–5; see 22:4–8; 26:9–15).
- the Way: The term the Way in the book of Acts refers to Christianity (see 19:9, 23; 24:14, 22). It is "the way of God" that teaches people "the way of salvation" (18:26; 16:17). See also John 14:6; 2 Peter 2:2.

Acts 9:10

- Ananias: See also 22:12. Ananias was a common name (consider the husband of Sapphira, 5:1, and the Jewish high priest [AD 47–59], 23:2).
- a vision: See "Visions" Theme Note.

Acts 9:15

This man is My chosen instrument to carry My name before the Gentiles: In God's plan to spread the good news, the next step was to reach the Gentiles, that is, people from other nations (see 1:8; compare chapters 10–11).

Saul of Tarsus, also called Paul, was the one God chose for this task. God sent him to bring the message about Jesus to Gentiles, to kings, and also to the people of Israel.

The rest of the book of Acts shows how Paul faithfully carried out this mission from God (for example, 26:19–23).

Acts 9:16

As Jesus predicted, Paul suffered greatly for his faith (see 2 Corinthians 11:23–27; see Acts 13:45; 14:19; 16:22–27; 21:30–31; 26:21; 2 Timothy 1:11–12).

Acts 9:17

God gave Ananias a special role. He was to welcome Saul into the Christian community.

Ananias began by placing his hands on Saul. Through this act, Saul was healed and filled with the Holy Spirit.

Acts 9:20–21

Saul promptly began to proclaim Jesus: Saul's encounter with the heavenly Christ was genuine, shown by his enthusiastic and bold preaching. His direct declaration surprised many because he had previously caused great harm to the followers of Jesus in Jerusalem.

Acts 9:22–25

The people who heard Saul were confused and surprised. Even so, Saul clearly showed from the Scriptures that Jesus is the Messiah. His arguments were so strong that the Jews in Damascus who did not believe could not answer him.

This continued for some time (see Galatians 1:18). The people who heard Saul were confused and surprised. Even so, Saul clearly showed from the Scriptures that Jesus is the Messiah. His arguments were so strong that the Jews in Damascus who did not believe could not answer him.

This continued for some time in 2 Corinthians 11:32–33.

Acts 9:26–28

When Saul arrived in Jerusalem: The believers did not trust him at first. This was understandable. He had recently attacked and imprisoned Christians (8:3; 9:1, 13; 22:3, 4; 26:9–11).

Barnabas helped him. Barnabas, whose name means "Son of Encouragement" (4:36), brought Saul to the apostles. He told them how Saul had seen the Lord on the road to Damascus. He also explained how Saul had preached boldly in the name of Jesus there.

Barnabas convinced the apostles that Saul's conversion was real. So Saul stayed with them in Jerusalem. There, he continued to preach boldly about the Lord.

Paul later spoke about this visit in Galatians 1:18–19.

Acts 9:29

Once again, Saul debated with some Greek-speaking Jews. He spoke boldly and explained why Jesus is the Messiah.

Again, some people became angry and made a plan to kill him (see 9:22–24).

Acts 9:30

After the Christians heard about the plot, they sent Saul away again (see 9:25). This time he went to Tarsus, his hometown, the capital of Cilicia (see 21:39; 22:3; 23:34; compare Galatians 1:21).

Acts 9:31

- This verse is one of several in Acts that describe how the church grew in numbers and in faithfulness (see also 2:41; 4:4; 5:14; 6:1, 7; 12:24; 21:20).
- The first Christians were learning an important truth: "The fear of the LORD is the beginning of wisdom." This means that true knowledge starts with honoring and respecting God (Proverbs 1:7; 9:10; compare Job 28:28; Psalm 111:10; Ecclesiastes 12:13; see Luke 7:16).

As they learned to honor God, they grew stronger in their faith. Their reverence for the Lord helped the church grow (compare Acts 2:43; 19:17).

Acts 9:32–43

- These verses describe Peter's traveling ministry in Judea, especially in towns along the seacoast. As he traveled, God gave him power to do miracles. Peter healed a man named Aeneas and raised a woman named Dorcas from the dead.

Jesus had promised that his disciples would do such works (John 14:12).

- Luke often tells stories in pairs. For example, he tells of a man being healed and then a woman being healed (see Luke 13:10–17; 14:1–6). In this passage, Peter heals both a man and a woman.

The people in that area were deeply affected by these miracles. Many people turned to the Lord and believed (Acts 9:35, 42).

Acts 9:43

stayed for several days in Joppa with a tanner named Simon: A tanner worked with animal skins to make leather. This job required contact with dead animals.

Many Jews considered this kind of work unclean. Because Peter stayed in the home of a tanner, it may show that he was not strict about some Jewish traditions (see Galatians 2:11–14).

Acts 10:1–8

- a centurion: This was the highest rank for an officer in the Roman army who was not commissioned. He led a century, a group of about 100 men. Luke often describes centurions positively (10:22; 21:32; 22:25–26; 23:17, 23; 27:6, 11, 43; 28:16; Luke 7:1–10; 23:47).

Luke wanted to show that Christianity was not against Roman officials or institutions. It could, like Judaism, be permitted in the Roman Empire (see Acts Book Introduction, "Purposes of Acts: Politics").

- in what was called the Italian Regiment: A regiment included six centuries; a Roman legion was usually divided into ten regiments. The New Testament mentions the Italian Regiment and the Imperial Regiment (Acts 27:1).

Acts 10:2

devout and God-fearing: Gentiles described as God-fearing admired Judaism's high ethical standards. However, they were not ready to undergo circumcision or fully convert to Judaism (see 13:43).

Christianity appealed to these Gentiles who worshiped God (18:7; see 13:48; 16:30; 17:4, 12, 17). These individuals were open to the message of the gospel that announced that "there is peace with God through Jesus Christ" (10:36).

Acts 10:3

In Acts, visions often happen while people are praying (9:3–6, 10–16; 10:2–6, 9–12; 11:5–9; 12:9–17; 18:9–10; 22:17–21; 23:11). These visions are not random. They show God's saving work and give divine guidance and encouragement.

Acts 10:9–16

God gave Peter the same vision three times to confirm it was true (see Genesis 41:32; 2 Corinthians 13:1).

Acts 10:14

See Leviticus 11 for a list of animals that Jewish laws have declared impure and ceremonially unclean.

Acts 10:17

Peter was puzzling over: The events that followed would clarify the meaning of the vision (10:17–48; see 11:1–18). Peter should not hesitate to enter or eat in a non-Jewish (Gentile) home because God has accepted and cleansed them.

Acts 10:25–26

Cornelius ... fell at his feet to worship him: This act was probably more than just bowing to an important person of rank. The Bible says worship is for God alone (see 14:11–17; Exodus 20:3; Deuteronomy 5:7; Matthew 22:37–38; Mark 12:29–30; Luke 10:27; 1 Corinthians 10:14; Colossians 3:5; 1 Peter 4:3; 1 John 5:21; Revelation 4:10; 9:20; 22:8–9).

Peter was just a fellow human being whom Cornelius should not worship.

Acts 10:34–35

- God does not show favoritism: See Deuteronomy 10:17; 2 Chronicles 19:7; Job 34:19; Luke 20:21; Romans 2:11; Galatians 2:6; Colossians 3:25; 1 Peter 1:17.

The application of this principle is the meaning of Peter's vision (10:9–16).

- welcomes those from every nation who fear Him and do what is right: See Romans 10:11–13.

Acts 10:36–43

Peter often emphasizes the role of the apostles as witnesses to the good news (the message about Jesus's

life, death, and resurrection). He reminds his listeners that they had direct contact with Jesus.

The apostles ate and drank with Jesus after he rose from the dead (see Luke 24:41–43). They saw him alive again. Because they were eyewitnesses of his resurrection, they could testify that Jesus had defeated death (see Acts 3:15; 4:33; 13:30–31).

Jesus chose the original apostles ahead of time to be his witnesses (see 1:12–26). Later, others continued this work. For example, Paul and Barnabas preached and taught in the name of Jesus Christ (see 9:15; 14:1–3; 26:16).

Acts 10:43

- Based on what they saw and heard, the apostles could declare that Jesus of Nazareth was the one about whom all the prophets spoke (10:39–42). The whole message and purpose of Scripture center on Christ (see Luke 24:25–27, 44–47; John 5:39).
- The main point of their message was that everyone who believes in Jesus will have sins forgiven through his name (see Luke 24:47).

Acts 10:44–48

On the day of Pentecost, Peter told the people that if they stopped sinning, repented, asked forgiveness from God, and received baptism in the name of Jesus Christ, they would "receive the gift of the Holy Spirit" (2:38; see also 19:1–7).

As Cornelius and his household listened to Peter's message, they received the Holy Spirit just like the Jews had earlier. This event confirmed again that God did not favor one group over another (10:34–35). This event is similar to the day of Pentecost in Jerusalem (2:1–47). It shows that the power of the Holy Spirit now came to the Gentiles as well (1:8; 2:39).

Acts 10:48

Cornelius asked Peter to stay for a few days with them, possibly because he needed more instruction in the Christian faith.

Acts 11:1–18

Jews traditionally kept themselves separate and did not eat or interact in a social setting with Gentiles (10:28; 22:21–22; see John 4:9, 27; 18:28; Galatians 2:12–14). The Jewish Christians in Jerusalem learned that Gentiles had received the word of God. Then they criticized Peter's unusual actions and asked for an explanation, which Peter provided.

Acts 11:4–17

Peter reviewed what had happened. He explained that God had directed the whole series of events (11:12). Peter ate with Gentiles (non-Jews) because God made it evident that he should (11:4–12). Peter then saw the Holy Spirit come upon the Gentiles, realizing God accepted and blessed them like Jews who trusted in Jesus (11:15–17; see 1:5). Peter followed God's will by admitting Gentiles to the church.

Acts 11:18

Peter gave a clear and careful explanation. Those who had objected were convinced. They saw that God was at work in the Gentiles' believing in Jesus and in their receiving eternal life.

However, the question of including Gentiles was not finished. Soon it would lead to a serious crisis in the church (15:1–35; see also Paul's letter to the Galatians).

Acts 11:19–26

- After Stephen's death, persecution forced Christians to move to other areas (8:1–3). They traveled as far as Phoenicia, Cyprus, and Antioch.
- Antioch in Syria was a busy, diverse city. It was the third-largest city in the Roman Empire, after Rome and Alexandria. Antioch played a key role in spreading the Christian message to non-Jewish people.

Acts 11:20

Jewish Christians from Cyprus and Cyrene made the first organized effort to teach Gentiles about Jesus.

Acts 11:21–24

As with the household of Cornelius, many Gentiles believed in Jesus. The growth of Christian faith among Gentiles had to remain in harmony with the church at Jerusalem. So, the Jerusalem Christians sent Barnabas to Antioch to oversee the developments there. Barnabas could see that God's blessing was on what was happening, so he supported it with joy.

Acts 11:25–26

Barnabas saw that Saul had a special gift for preaching and teaching. The wise judgment of Barnabus led to a successful ministry in Antioch.

Acts 11:26

The term Christians might have first been an insult. The Greek text uses this term in only two other New Testament passages (26:28; 1 Peter 4:16).

Acts 11:27–28

- some prophets: See “The Gift of Prophecy” Theme Note.
- Agabus: See also 21:10–12.

Acts 11:28

Claudius was the nephew of Tiberius Caesar (Luke 3:1). He ruled as Roman emperor from AD 41 to AD 54.

His last wife was his niece Agrippina. Claudius adopted her son, Nero.

Acts 11:29–30

Agabus’s prophecy resulted in the Christians in Antioch helping the Jewish Christians in Judea. They gave as much as they could and trusted the funds to Barnabas and Saul. This act of love and support showed the difference Jesus had made in their lives. Saul (also called Paul) mentions this visit in his letter to the Galatians (Galatians 2:1–10).

Acts 11:30

This is the first mention in the book of Acts of elders as officers in the Christian church (see also 14:23; 15:2–23; 16:4; 20:17–35; 21:18; compare 1 Timothy 3:1–7; Titus 1:5–9).

Acts 12:1–5

- Jesus had prophesied that his followers would experience persecution and difficulty (Luke 11:49–51). For the first time since his death, Roman authorities acted violently against the church. James, the brother of John, was among the first disciples Jesus called (Mark 1:16–20; Luke 5:1–11). He was one of the first Christians killed because of his faith.
- King Herod Agrippa took action to intentionally harm the church (Acts 12:20–23). It is possible that doing this was meant to strengthen his political alignment with the Jewish people. The letter of James, the brother of Jesus, was probably written after this persecution effort to the Christians who were scattered (see 8:1–4; James Book Introduction, “Date of Writing”).

Acts 12:4

Herod had Peter guarded by four squads of soldiers, making it impossible for the apostle to escape (compare 12:6). God was in control, even though the circumstances seemed impossible for humans to overcome (compare 4:27–31; Genesis 18:14; Jeremiah 32:17, 27; Matthew 19:26; Mark 10:27; Luke 1:37; 18:27).

Acts 12:5

the church was fervently praying: God answers the earnest prayers of his people (12:6–17; see Luke 11:1–13; 18:1–8; compare Matthew 7:7–11; John 15:7; Philippians 4:6–7; James 5:16; 1 John 3:22).

Acts 12:6–19

God, through an angel, guided Peter out of prison. Peter reunited with his praying friends, and God sent him to continue proclaiming the good news about Jesus. The message advanced by God’s power, even when the church and apostles faced strong opposition and discouragement.

Acts 12:7–11

See “Angels” Theme Note.

Acts 12:12

Mary, the mother of John Mark, had a home where Christians often gathered. John Mark later worked with Barnabas and Saul to spread the gospel (12:25).

Acts 12:13–17

Rhoda was very surprised when Peter appeared, so she left him standing at the closed door. She and the other Christians thought God’s answer to their prayers was amazing (12:5).

Acts 12:18–23

When Peter was missing after a thorough search, Herod questioned the guards and executed them (see 16:27). However, Herod himself then experienced a painful death. God punished him for his pride when he accepted the people’s worship. The ancient Jewish historian Josephus provides more details about the death of Herod Agrippa I (Josephus, Antiquities 19.8.1–2).

Acts 12:24–25

Herod died from a terrible illness (12:23). Meanwhile, the Christian church continued to grow and share the message of the gospel freely (28:31).

Acts 13:1

- prophets and teachers: See “The Gift of Prophecy” Theme Note; also see 1 Corinthians 12:28–29; Ephesians 4:11.
- The name Simeon suggests a Jewish background (see Genesis 29:33; Luke 2:25; 3:30). He is also called Niger (which means “the black mane”). This suggests that he was probably African.

- Lucius is a Latin name. He came from Cyrene, the capital of Libya in North Africa. He was probably one of the preachers from Cyrene who brought the Christian message to Antioch (Acts 11:20).
- Manaen grew up with King Herod Antipas. He was probably Luke's source for understanding Antipas's thoughts and actions (see Luke 9:7–9).
- Barnabas and Saul play important roles in the following story.

Acts 13:1–3

prophets and teachers: these leaders of the church at Antioch spent a lot of time in worship and prayer. They had an intense desire to do the Lord's will, and they fasted to spiritually prepare themselves to receive guidance from God. As they prayed, the Holy Spirit spoke to them.

The church set apart Barnabas and Saul, recognizing God's clear call for them to do a special work in his name. The inner journey these Christians took to pray and listen to God matched their outer journey of service. Their service included proclaiming the Christian faith and performing works of healing and salvation.

Acts 13:3

they laid their hands on them: They performed this holy act only after more fasting and prayer. The Pastoral Letters (1 Timothy, 2 Timothy, and Titus) caution against appointing someone as a Christian leader without proper care and background checks (1 Timothy 5:22). At this point, the church at Antioch sent Barnabas and Saul as its representatives for the mission.

Acts 13:4

- Barnabas and Saul were commissioned by the church at Antioch to go on their first missionary journey. They were guided by the Holy Spirit.
- Seleucia was the ancient seaport city of Antioch, about 20 kilometers (12 miles) west of the city at the opening of the Orontes River.
- from there to Cyprus: Barnabas was from Cyprus, the next stop on their journey (4:36).

Acts 13:5

When they arrived in Salamis on the eastern end of Cyprus, they visited the Jewish synagogues (see study note on 9:2). There, Jews could hear and respond to the Christian message. They would also meet people who had converted to Judaism (those who had chosen to follow Israel's God; see study note on 13:43). They also met Gentiles (non-Jews) who were seeking God. These Gentiles are sometimes called God-fearers (people who worshiped the God of Israel but had not fully become Jews; see study note on 10:2).

Acts 13:6

- Paphos: This major city was on the southwest coast of Cyprus, a location that had strategic significance.
- a Jewish sorcerer and false prophet named Bar-Jesus: People from the east who practiced magic like this man often had significant power to influence people in the Greek and Roman world.

Acts 13:6–12

In Paphos, a false prophet caused a power struggle. This resulted in a display of God's power, and the Roman proconsul (governor) became a Christian.

Acts 13:7–8

Sergius Paulus, the proconsul (governor), was an intelligent person. He had interest in the teachings of Barnabas and Saul. But Elymas (the sorcerer's Greco-Roman name) recognized a challenge to his power and strongly opposed the message of Barnabas and Saul.

Acts 13:9

Luke marks an important shift in using the name Saul (a Hebrew name) and Paul (a Greco-Roman name). This may show that Paul is now focusing on his mission to Gentiles (non-Jews). For the rest of Acts, Luke calls him Paul, except when Paul tells the story of his conversion (as in 22:7, 13; 26:14).

Acts 13:10–11

Paul, who had become the main speaker, confronted the sorcerer. He rebuked his false claims, exposed his deceit, and announced God's judgment (see 8:20–24). The sorcerer became blind immediately, and this condition lasted for a significant period of time. This event showed the power and truthfulness of the gospel message over the sorcerer's false claims.

Acts 13:12

The teaching about the Lord included a miracle showing divine power (compare Mark 1:21–27). This was because it was a teaching about the living God (see Acts 14:15).

Acts 13:13–14

- They arrived at the port of Perga. From there, major roads led to the interior of the land beyond the Taurus Mountains.
- At this point, John Mark left the team for unknown reasons (see study note on 15:36–41). He might have

been unhappy that the gospel was advancing into non-Jewish lands. Perhaps he missed his home or was unable to continue the challenging journey. Whatever the reasons, he returned to the familiar and comfortable Jewish area of Jerusalem.

Acts 13:14

Paul and Barnabas traveled inland to the high country and reached Pisidian Antioch. This Antioch was in the Roman province of Galatia in Asia Minor. This city is not the same one as the city of Antioch in Syria.

As usual, the apostles began their work at the synagogue (see study note on 9:2; compare 13:5; 14:1; 17:1, 2, 10, 17; 18:4, 19; 19:8).

Acts 13:15

People chosen to read in the synagogue read the usual Scriptures for the day. This included one passage from the books of Moses and another from the prophets (see Luke 4:16–28). Then the synagogue leaders invited the visitors to share a word of encouragement for the people.

Acts 13:16–41

Paul accepted the invitation, and signaled for his audience to be quiet (compare 19:33; 21:40). He began to clearly proclaim the good news about Jesus. This is Paul's first major speech in the book of Acts. It serves as a model of the way he preached to a Jewish audience (see 22:1–21).

Acts 13:17–22

To establish common ground with his audience, Paul traced Jewish history starting from the Israelite exodus from Egypt. He emphasized:

- the Israelites' escape from Egyptian slavery,
- their settlement in Canaan,
- the establishment of the kingdom of Israel,
- the removal of King Saul, and
- the special role of King David.

Acts 13:22

Even though he sinned, David was a man who desired to completely follow God's ways (for example, 2 Samuel 11–12).

Acts 13:23–25

At this point, Paul shifted to the main point of his message. Jesus, descended from King David's family line, was the Savior God promised to Israel. John the Baptist prepared the way for the Messiah (God's chosen leader). John called Israel to repent and be baptized. John was a humble servant who prepared the way for the one whose coming he announced.

Acts 13:26–37

Paul reviewed how Jesus had been treated with shame, including an unjust sentence and death. But God raised Jesus from the dead, and many witnesses saw him. This message is good news, because through Jesus people can receive forgiveness of sins. But people must respond with faith, or they will face serious consequences.

Acts 13:31

The resurrection of Jesus was confirmed by many witnesses.

Acts 13:38–41

Paul urged his audience to believe the message about Jesus, through whom there is forgiveness for your sins.

Acts 13:39

A life of faith is necessary to be right with God. The law of Moses alone could not provide this ability to have a right relationship (Psalm 14:1–3; see Romans 3:9–20).

Acts 13:40–41

Paul ended his message with a strong warning (see Hebrews 2:3). Do not ignore, neglect, or reject the gospel, or you will encounter serious consequences.

Acts 13:42–43

The message attracted many people, and many of them chose to believe.

Acts 13:43

- Full converts to Judaism (also called proselytes) were Gentiles who had gone through the rite of circumcision to become full members of the Jewish community, observing the Jewish law (see also 2:11; 6:5; Matthew 23:15).
- the grace of God: The grace of God is an important idea in the New Testament. It describes God's kindness and favor that people do not earn, shown most clearly through Jesus Christ.

Acts 13:44–49

People were excited by the preaching of the apostles. A large gathering formed the next week. This response made some Jews jealous (see 4:1–2; 5:17). This was

because Paul's ministry was attracting more converts than Judaism (13:43). These Jews made verbal attacks against Paul and his ministry (see 6:8–12; 18:6; 19:9; Matthew 23:13).

Paul responded to the attacks with a bold statement that the jealous Jews had rejected their past opportunities to hear the word of God. Paul would now proclaim the message of salvation to Gentiles, following the Lord's command in Scripture (see Acts 10:34–35). The local Gentiles welcomed the gospel, and many accepted it. They spread the Lord's message throughout the region.

Acts 13:50–51

Jewish opposition once again forced Paul and Barnabas out of their district. They shook the dust off their feet as a sign of rejection, as Jesus had taught his disciples (see Matthew 10:14–15; Mark 6:11–12; Luke 9:5–6; 10:10–11). That place was then treated as pagan (not worshiping the true God). Paul and Barnabas left that place in order to reach other people who might be more open to the message of new life in Christ.

Acts 13:52

Even though they probably encountered harassment and persecution, the disciples were filled with joy and with the Holy Spirit (compare 5:41; 16:23–25; Matthew 5:10–12; 2 Corinthians 8:2; 1 Thessalonians 1:6).

Acts 14:1

- Paul and Barnabas traveled on their mission to the next town, Iconium (now called Konya). This city is east of Pisidian Antioch on a high plateau in south-central Asia Minor. Iconium was near several important trade routes.
- In their usual way, Paul and Barnabas began their ministry by speaking powerfully in the Jewish synagogue. Their teachings led to a positive response from both Jews and Greeks.

Acts 14:2

Once again, Paul and Barnabas faced Jews who opposed them. These people rejected the Christian message (the good news about Jesus) and also influenced the Gentiles to think wrongly about it.

Acts 14:3

- Because the apostles were sustained by the Holy Spirit, they were strong enough to confront verbal attacks. They continued to preach the good news that God's grace was for both Gentiles and Jews.
- boldly: The book of Acts often shows how the Holy Spirit gave courage to Christians (see 2:14; 4:9–10, 13; 7:2–53; 8:30–35; 9:27–28; 18:26; 19:8; 22:3–21; 23:1–6; 28:16–20, 23–31).
- The Holy Spirit also affirmed the Christian message with signs and wonders (compare 5:12–16; 15:12; 16:18; 19:11).

Acts 14:4

- The message preached by the apostles required people to decide whether to trust in Jesus. Opinions were clearly divided.
- Paul and Barnabas are called apostles for the first time (also in 14:14). This broadened the meaning of the word apostle. It no longer referred only to the Twelve. The Gospel of Luke shows an earlier example of this. Jesus sent out 70 (or 72) others as messengers (see Luke 10:1, 17).

Paul and Barnabas's message continued the work of the original apostles. They were ready to encounter difficulty and abuse for it, just as the earlier apostles had done (5:41; 14:19; 20:24; 21:13–14; see also Romans 8:35–38; 2 Corinthians 4:8–17).

Acts 14:6

- Lycaonia was a southern region of the Roman province of Galatia. Its major cities were Lystra, Derbe, Laranda, and Iconium. Acts reports two more visits by Paul to Lycaonia (16:1–5; 18:23). Paul's letter to the Galatians was probably addressed to scattered believers in the churches of Lycaonia (see Galatians Book Introduction, "Recipients").
- Lystra was about 40 kilometers (25 miles) south or southwest of Iconium.
- Derbe was about 50 kilometers (30 miles) southeast of Lystra. It was on a busy main road that went from Iconium and Lystra towards the east to Tarsus, the capital of Cilicia.

Acts 14:8–20

Paul healed a man who could not use his feet. This is similar to an earlier event in 3:1–12. In Acts, Paul's work is shown as similar to Peter's work. The many signs and wonders done among the Jews were also done among the Gentiles.

Acts 14:9

saw that he had faith to be healed: Paul, filled with the Holy Spirit, sensed the man's spiritual openness and hope for God's help and intervention (see 9:17).

Acts 14:11–13

Zeus was the main god worshiped in Lystra, and the city had a temple for him. The people thought Barnabas was Zeus, likely because he seemed more impressive or powerful. They thought Paul was Hermes because he was the main speaker.

The people of Lystra believed the gods were visiting them again. This idea comes from a well-known story by the poet Ovid. In that story, Zeus and Hermes visited the area but were not recognized, except by an old couple (see Ovid, Metamorphoses 8.616–724). Because of this, the people tried to honor Paul and Barnabas as gods.

Acts 14:13–18

The apostles opposed the people's worship of idols and their attempt to offer sacrifices to them. They directed the people's worship to the living God. The apostles were representatives of God as they shared the good news of the Christian message.

Acts 14:19–20

- The crowd changed their minds when some Jews came from Antioch and Iconium and easily turned them against the apostles.
- They stoned Paul and dragged him outside the city: Paul later referred to this time of persecution to teach a lesson (2 Timothy 3:11–12).
- presuming he was dead: That Paul got up and went back into the city suggests that God healed his wounds with a miracle.

Acts 14:20

the next day he left: Paul later returned to Lystra on his second missionary journey (16:1).

Acts 14:22–23

- The apostles worked hard to stay in contact with those who had declared their Christian faith. These new disciples needed care, support, and encouragement (15:32, 41; 16:40; 18:23; see 1 Thessalonians 3:2; 4:18; 5:14).
- Paul and Barnabas appointed elders: See "Church Leaders" Theme Note.

Acts 14:26–28

When Paul and Barnabas returned to Antioch after their first missionary journey (a trip to share the good news and start churches), they gathered the church and gave a full report. They told how they had shared the good news and helped new believers grow as disciples. They gave credit to God, who had opened the way for Gentiles to believe (see 11:18; 1 Corinthians 16:9; 2 Corinthians 2:12).

Similar reports always emphasized God's work through the ministries of his servants (Acts 15:4, 12; 21:19; see Romans 15:17–18; 1 Corinthians 3:5–9; 15:10–11).

Acts 15:1

These men from Judea were Jewish Christians who taught that circumcision and conversion to Judaism were necessary for salvation. The main issue was how to welcome non-Jews into the Christian community. Paul wrote his letter to the Galatians around this time to oppose the same teaching in Galatia (see Galatians Book Introduction, "Date of Writing").

Acts 15:2–3

The church in Antioch decided to send some delegates (representatives) to Jerusalem. They went to discuss this issue with the apostles and elders there. On the way, they visited believers in Phoenicia and Samaria. In these places, the Christian faith had already spread widely (chapter 8).

Acts 15:4–21

The first council of the church met to resolve the dispute concerning Gentiles and circumcision (15:1–2).

Acts 15:5

These Pharisees believed Jesus was the Messiah, but they still insisted on strict adherence to the law of Moses. Paul strongly opposed their perspective (see Galatians 1:6–9; 2:14–3:14).

Acts 15:7–11

Peter recalled his experience in Cornelius's household (chapter 10). He argued that God had accepted the Gentiles without circumcision by giving them the Holy Spirit. The grace of the Lord Jesus was available to people from all nations.

Acts 15:13–19

James, the brother of Jesus, said that the turning of the Gentiles (non-Jewish people) to God agreed with Scripture. He strongly argued that it was against God's will to place extra rules on Gentiles who wanted to join God's people.

Acts 15:14

Simon: This was Peter's original name (see Matthew 16:17–19).

Acts 15:15–19

Because God's prophets had predicted the conversion and inclusion of the Gentiles, James argued that the Gentiles should be accepted as Gentiles, without requiring them to practice Judaism (15:1).

Acts 15:20

- Eating food offered to idols is sinful when it involves active participation in idol worship (see Exodus 20:4; Deuteronomy 5:8; Revelation 2:14, 20). However, Paul teaches that eating such food is not always wrong in itself. The concern is whether eating causes a fellow believer with a weak conscience to sin (1 Corinthians 8:4–13). Paul also warns against eating at a pagan temple, since that amounts to sharing in idol worship. But he permits eating food bought in the market or served at a meal without asking about its origin (10:14–30).
- sexual immorality: This was a common practice in the Greek world but is always sinful (Exodus 20:14; Deuteronomy 5:18; Galatians 5:19).
- the meat of strangled animals: The law of Moses prohibited eating meat with blood in it or consuming blood (Leviticus 17:10–12, 13–14). This was because "the life of all flesh is its blood" (Leviticus 17:14). Also, "it is the blood that makes atonement for the soul" (see Leviticus 17:11 and study note). Noah, the ancestor of both Gentiles and Jews, first received this command from God (Genesis 9:4).

Acts 15:22–29

The Jerusalem church selected two leaders to report its decision. They carried a letter from the apostles and elders in Jerusalem that explained the terms of the agreement.

Acts 15:29

Farewell: This is a common Greek greeting used to end a letter. In the New Testament, it appears only here. Paul often ended his letters with a stronger focus on God's grace and peace (for example, 1 Corinthians 16:23–24; 2 Corinthians 13:13; see Ephesians 6:23–24; Philippians 4:23; Colossians 4:18; 1 Thessalonians 5:23–28; 1 Timothy 6:21).

Acts 15:30–31

The Christians in Antioch were very happy to learn they did not need to convert to Judaism or follow all the laws of Moses. With the dispute settled, they could continue teaching and preaching without interruption.

Acts 15:36–41

The discordant separation of Paul and Barnabas is indicated by a very strong word in Greek (Their disagreement was so sharp). They were two dedicated men who disagreed about giving John Mark, Barnabas's cousin, a second chance to join their missionary journey (Colossians 4:10). John Mark had left them in Pamphylia (see Acts 13:13). Eventually, Paul and John Mark made peace (2 Timothy 4:11).

Acts 15:40–41

After disagreeing with Barnabas about John Mark, Paul chose Silas as his partner for a second missionary journey through Syria and Cilicia. The two men traveled by land to visit Derbe and Lystra. They explained the decision of the Jerusalem council and strengthened believers in their faith.

Acts 16:1–3

Paul returned to churches that he and Barnabas had established on their previous journey.

Acts 16:3

Paul had Timothy circumcised to enhance Timothy's acceptance and effectiveness as a Jew in Jewish circles. This was not the same as Titus, who was a full Gentile ("Greek"; Galatians 2:3).

Elsewhere Paul clarified that it makes no difference to God whether one is circumcised or not circumcised (Romans 2:25–29; Galatians 5:6; 6:15). Paul was prepared to use any legitimate means to communicate the good news about Jesus to different audiences (1 Corinthians 9:20–21).

Acts 16:4–5

Paul and Silas faithfully communicated the decisions of the Jerusalem council. The wisdom of the decision was indicated as the churches were strengthened in their faith and grew larger every day (compare 2:41; 4:4; 5:14; 6:1; 9:31; 21:20).

Acts 16:6–10

God directed the missionaries' travels: The Holy Spirit had prevented them from proceeding westward into the province of Asia, the Spirit of Jesus did not allow them to go north to Bithynia, and then Paul had a

vision calling them to go northwest over the Aegean Sea to Macedonia.

In the book of Acts, God's Spirit guided his servants in many ways, including:

- through visions from God (see also 9:10; 10:9–16; 22:18),
- direct intuition (compare 8:29, 39; 10:19; 20:22),
- advice from other believers (compare 15:29),
- guidance through prayer (13:2, 4),
- understanding through Scripture (28:25–27), and
- prophecy (11:28).

The Holy Spirit's guidance helped them accomplish their mission to be Christ's witnesses (1:8; see also 4:8, 31; 11:24; 13:9).

Acts 16:8

Troas was a major port on the Aegean Sea and an important city in the Roman Empire. Paul often visited major cities like Troas, Athens, Corinth, and Ephesus. Once the Christian faith was established in larger cities, local Christian workers could continue to share the good news with smaller nearby communities (for example, Epaphras took the message from Ephesus to Colossae (Colossians 1:7; 4:12–13).

Acts 16:9–10

a vision: See "Visions" Theme Note.

Acts 16:10

we: The shift from they to we suggests that Luke traveled with Paul from Troas to Philippi (16:10–17). Later, Luke joined Paul again at Philippi and sailed with him to Troas. Then they went to Miletus, and from Miletus to Jerusalem (20:5–15; 21:1–18).

After Paul spent two years in prison in Caesarea, Luke traveled with him to Rome (27:1–28:16).

Acts 16:11

- Samothrace is a small island with many mountains. It is west or northwest of the Hellespont (the strait between Asia Minor and Europe). It is about 32 kilometers (20 miles) from the coast of Thrace.
- Neapolis, now known as Kavala, was the seaport for Philippi and the eastern end of the famous Via Egnatia (the Egnatian Way), which extended from Rome to Asia.

Acts 16:12

At Philippi, about 17 kilometers (10 miles) from the coast of Neapolis, Paul began his mission work in Europe.

Acts 16:13

The Jewish community at Philippi was too small to have a synagogue, which required ten adult males. Instead, Jews met for prayer in an open space by the Gangites (now called Angista) River that provided privacy, quiet, and water for Jewish purification rites.

Acts 16:13–36

Luke shares stories of three people in Philippi affected by the gospel:

- a wealthy woman (16:14–15),
- a demon-possessed slave girl exploited for money (16:16–21), and
- a middle-ranking officer (16:23–36).

Acts 16:14–15

- The first person whose life Christ changed in Philippi was Lydia. She was a successful business owner from Thyatira (modern Akhisar). This city in western Asia Minor was well-known for exporting fine fabrics, woven cloth, and linen items. Lydia accepted the gospel message, and Paul baptized her and her household (compare 16:32–33).
- One of Lydia's first actions as a true believer in the Lord was to extend hospitality to the visiting missionaries. Hospitality is an important Christian virtue (see Matthew 25:31–46; Romans 12:13; 16:23; 1 Timothy 3:2; Titus 1:8; Hebrews 13:2; 1 Peter 4:9; 3 John 1:5–8; compare Genesis 18:1–8; 19:1–3; 24:23–33).

Acts 16:16–18

- The second example of a changed life in Philippi is a slave girl who had a spirit that enabled her to tell the future (a demon that gave her special knowledge).
- Even though the demon inside her spoke the truth, Paul, like Jesus, did not allow it to share the Christian message (compare Mark 1:25, 34; 3:11–12; Luke 4:35, 41). The Lord commanded that his disciples, not those who oppose the message, should proclaim the gospel (Acts 1:8; 9:15; 26:15–18; Matthew 28:18–20; Luke 24:46–49; John 20:21; see Acts 22:15).

Acts 16:19–21

- As in the ministry of Jesus, the gospel sometimes threatened existing business interests (see also

19:25–27; Mark 5:1–20). Those who were exploiting the slave girl attacked the Christian missionaries and dragged them to the authorities as criminals. They blamed them for causing trouble, used racial bias ("These men are Jews"), and appealed to the Philippians' pride ("us Romans"). The Philippians were proud Roman citizens of a Roman colony.
- customs that are unlawful: By law, Jews were not permitted to make converts of Romans.

Acts 16:22–24

They took all necessary security measures. They wanted to guarantee that Paul and Silas did not escape after they stripped and beat them with wooden rods (see 22:24–26; 2 Corinthians 6:5; 11:23–25). However, as at Christ's tomb, human efforts could not stop God's intervention (Matthew 27:65).

Acts 16:25

Paul and Silas, like the apostles suffering abuse in Jerusalem, were full of joy. They rejoiced because God considered them "worthy of suffering disgrace for the Name" (5:41).

Acts 16:26

The strong earthquake reminds us of the great earthquake that happened at the resurrection of Jesus (Matthew 28:2–3).

Acts 16:27

The Roman jailer knew he could lose his life if the prisoners he guarded escaped. This was a common practice (12:19; 27:42; compare Code of Justinian 9.4.4).

Acts 16:27–36

Luke's third story in Philippi is of the Philippian jailer who, shaken by what had happened, responded in faith when challenged to accept the Lord Jesus and be saved. He was baptized with his household and rejoiced in his newfound faith as he reached out with hospitality to the preachers.

Acts 16:29–30

Paul and Silas impressed the jailer with their cheerful faith, calm attitude during the crisis, and concern for his safety (16:25, 28). Whatever the jailer had understood of Paul's message before the crisis, God inspired him to cry out for help.

Acts 16:31–34

Paul and Silas directed the jailer to a faith in Christ that brings blessing both to him and to his family. The whole household received Christian instruction, and their response was expressed in baptism and the offering of hospitality to Paul and Silas.

Acts 16:37–39

- Paul and Silas were Roman citizens, so it was illegal to beat and imprison them (16:22–24). When the city officials learned this, they were understandably alarmed because they had broken Roman law.
- Let them come themselves and escort us out!: Paul used his rights as a Roman citizen to save his reputation and protect the Christian message from receiving a bad name. Luke wanted to show that Christianity should have the same status as Judaism in the Roman Empire as a legal religion.

The Christian faith was not at odds with Roman citizenship. It was important to note that Paul used his rights as a Roman citizen. He was willing to use his privileges as a citizen to promote Christianity in a hostile world (comparing 22:25–27).

Acts 16:40

This meeting in Lydia's home encouraged the Philippian Christians. They had to deal with the results of the missionaries' work in their city.

Acts 17:1–3

- Amphipolis was a Roman military post on the Egnatian Way in northeastern Macedonia.
- Apollonia, named after the Greek god Apollo, was also on the Egnatian Way.
- Thessalonica was a good place to begin ministry because it had a Jewish synagogue (see study note on 9:2). Paul preached there for three consecutive Sabbath days. He explained the Scriptures and showed how they are fulfilled in Jesus (how they come true in him).

Acts 17:1–9

After traveling through Macedonia to Thessalonica, Paul first preached to the Jews in the synagogue (Romans 1:16). As in other places, there was a mixed response.

Acts 17:4

- God-fearing Greeks: See study note on 10:2.
- Luke often draws attention to women who joined the Christian movement (17:4, 12, 34; see also 5:14; 8:12; 16:13–15, 31–34; 18:26; 21:9).

Acts 17:5–7

Once again, the opponents of the Christian faith regarded it as a disruption and a threat (compare 16:19–21). Ironically, they formed a mob and then accused Paul and Silas of causing trouble by disturbing the peace and defying Caesar. These were serious charges that threatened the stability of the Roman Empire (compare Luke 23:2).

Acts 17:8–9

The charges did not stand up when the officials examined them. So they released Jason and the other believers after they paid a bond (money given as a promise to return if required).

Luke shows that Christianity was not a political threat to the Roman Empire. For this reason, he argues that it should be treated as a permitted religion and not attacked for political reasons.

Acts 17:10–12

Because of strong opposition in Thessalonica, the believers sent Paul and Silas to Berea, about 80.5 kilometers (50 miles) west of Thessalonica. They had a better reception in Berea than in Thessalonica. Many Jews and prominent Greek women and men became Christians.

The Bereans were good examples because they were open-minded, eager to learn, good listeners, thoughtful, and paid attention to the teachings of Scripture. Their resulting faith had a strong foundation.

Acts 17:13–15

Paul recognized how strong and ongoing this persecution (hostile treatment for following Jesus) was when he wrote to the Thessalonians (1 Thessalonians 2:14–16).

Acts 17:16–17

Athens, like Alexandria and Tarsus, was proud of its learning and love of ideas. People there spent time studying and discussing different philosophies (ways of thinking about life and the world) that were popular at that time.

Acts 17:16–34

In this chapter, we see Paul presented as a model witness for Christ, engaging the thinkers of his day and challenging them with the Christian message. Paul quoted writers his audience would be familiar with and showed the relevance of the gospel by dialoguing with them, critiquing their assumptions, and offering Jesus as a constructive alternative (see Colossians 1:28).

Paul reminded these proud intellectuals that there is a living God to whom all human beings are answerable; that they will be judged by him through Jesus, whom God raised from the dead; and that they should therefore repent and put their faith in Jesus.

Acts 17:18

- Epicurean philosophers followed Epicureanism, a Greek school of thought founded by Epicurus, who lived from 341 to 270 BC. Epicureans believed that the main goal of life was happiness. They did not define pleasure as physical excess, as some critics said. Instead, they valued peace of mind and freedom from fear. Many people in their time called them atheists because they did not believe the gods controlled human life. They also believed that death was simply the end of a person's existence. For safety and peace, they formed organized communities and lived apart from wider society.
- Stoic philosophers followed Stoicism, founded by Zeno of Citium, who lived from 335 to 263 BC. Stoicism became one of the most influential philosophies in the Greco-Roman world. Stoics believed that the universe was filled with Reason, which they sometimes called God or Providence. They believed this divine Reason could also be seen in human reason. As people grew in understanding, they could move from ignorance, which leads to vice, to true knowledge, which leads to virtue.

Stoics made detailed lists of virtues and vices. They also wrote household codes, which were instructions for family life. In some ways, Paul's teaching sounds similar, especially in his household codes and lists of virtues and vices (Galatians 5:19–23; Ephesians 5:22–33; Colossians 3:18–4:1; 1 Timothy 3:1–13; 5:1–6:1). However, Paul's message about the life, death, and resurrection of Jesus Christ was unfamiliar to these Greek philosophers.

- Their insulting use of the word babbler for Paul also shows that they looked down on him.

Acts 17:22–31

- Paul's sermon in Athens shows how well he could adapt his preaching of the good news (Romans 11:14; 1 Corinthians 9:19–23; 10:33; compare Acts 16:3; 17:2–3; 21:20–26). His Greek audience did not know the Scriptures or believe in one God like the Jews. However, they had a strong intellectual background. Paul connected with them using an Athenian inscription on an altar TO AN UNKNOWN GOD. He then

explained God's nature as the Creator (17:22–29), followed by God's purpose as the Redeemer (17:30–31).
- As he did in his letters (see 1 Corinthians 15:33; Titus 1:12), Paul also used lines from Greek poets. His sermon has several ideas similar to the Hymn to Zeus by Cleanthes, who lived around 315 to 240 BC. Paul likely quoted Epimenides, who wrote, "In him we live and move and exist" (Epimenides, Cretica, about 600 BC). Paul also quoted Aratus, a Stoic (a follower of Stoicism, a Greek philosophy that valued reason and virtue) from Cilicia, who wrote, "We are his offspring" (Aratus, Phaenomena 5).

By using these familiar sayings, Paul connected with his audience. Then he moved to his main message. He taught that God is one and not like idols made by humans (Acts 17:29). He also warned that God will judge the world through Jesus Christ, whom he raised from the dead.
Even though Paul spoke in ways that related to Greek culture and thought, his message clearly pointed to Christ. He challenged an educated but idol-worshiping audience to respond to the truth.

Acts 17:30

The idea of people's ignorance is carefully discussed both in the Old Testament law (Leviticus 4:2, 22, 27; 5:15, 17; Numbers 15:25, 27). It is also present in the New Testament (Ephesians 4:18; 1 Peter 1:14; 2:15; 2 Peter 3:5, 8). Paul was especially eager to correct ignorance (see Romans 10:13–15; 11:25; 1 Corinthians 10:1; 12:1; 2 Corinthians 1:8; 1 Thessalonians 4:13). The message of the gospel overcomes ignorance and calls all people to repent "and be baptized ... and receive the gift of the Holy Spirit" (see Acts 2:38).

Acts 17:32

The Athenians listened carefully to Paul until he spoke about the resurrection of the dead (17:31). At that point, some began to laugh and mock him. To Greek listeners, the idea of resurrection seemed foolish (see 1 Corinthians 15:12–19). In a similar way, the Jews in Jerusalem listened to Paul until he spoke about God accepting the Gentiles (Acts 22:22). Then they also rejected his message.

These examples show how the message of the good news can offend people because of their prejudices (strong opinions that keep them from accepting the truth; see 1 Corinthians 1:20–25).

Acts 17:34

- some joined him and believed: Some people joined Paul and became believers. His sermon did not only bring rejection; it also led to faith.

Two important people who believed are named: Dionysius and Damaris. Luke often places a man and a woman side by side in his writing to show that the message of the good news is for all people. By pairing men and women, he shows that both are equally important in God's work (for example, 5:1–11; 17:4, 12; Luke 14:1–6; 15:3–10).
- Dionysius was a member of the council of the Areopagus, the highest governing body of Athens.

Acts 18:1

In Roman times, political power in Achaia was centered in Corinth, an important city-state and a major center for trade. Corinth became known for widespread prostitution, sexual immorality (wrong sexual behavior), and drunkenness (see 1 Corinthians Book Introduction, "Setting").

Paul spent a great deal of time and effort building a Christian community there (see study note on Acts 16:8).

Acts 18:1–17

Paul spent 18 productive months preaching and teaching in Corinth. He started in the synagogue and then moved next door to the house of Titius Justus (18:1–11). Then Paul won an important case in court against his opponents (18:12–17).

Acts 18:2–3

- The Roman historian Suetonius mentions that the emperor Claudius Caesar ordered all Jews to leave Rome around AD 49 (Life of Claudius 25).
- Aquila and Priscilla were a remarkable husband and wife team in the early church. They worked as tentmakers, as did Paul. Paul probably lived and worked with Aquila and Priscilla during his time in Corinth (Acts 18:11; see Romans 16:3–4; 1 Corinthians 16:19).
- Paul had probably learned tentmaking when he was young. It was a Jewish custom to teach sons a manual trade, even if they planned to become rabbis or other kinds of professionals.

Acts 18:4–6

- Paul followed his usual practice of preaching to the Jews first. After encountering rejection and opposition, he then reached out to the Gentiles (13:42–49; see 3:25–26; 26:20; Romans 1:16; 2:10; 3:29, 30; 4:9–12).

- Paul probably wrote his letters to the Christians in Thessalonica after Silas and Timothy returned from Macedonia with a report on the situation there (see 1 Thessalonians 3:6; 2 Thessalonians Book Introduction, "Setting").

Acts 18:7

Titius Justus ("Titus the Just") was a Gentile who worshiped God. People like him are often called "God-fearers" (non-Jews who worship the God of Israel; see study note on 10:2). The name Titus was a common Roman name, so the second name or title Justus helps to tell him apart from the better-known Titus, who worked with Paul ("Titus" in 2 Corinthians 2:13; 7:6, 13; 8:6, 16, 23).

Acts 18:9–10

Paul encountered strong opposition in Corinth and feared another attack (18:6). The divine message comforted him (see 23:11; Psalm 34:4, 7, 19; Matthew 28:20). It encouraged him to continue his public ministry and promised God's protection (see Psalm 91:11; 2 Timothy 4:17).

Acts 18:12–13

The governor (or proconsul) of Achaia, Junius Gallio, was the older brother of the Roman philosopher Seneca. Seneca later served as a tutor to Emperor Nero.

An ancient inscription shows that Gallio was governor around AD 51–52. This helps scholars date Paul's visit to Corinth to about the same time.

Acts 18:14–17

Gallio's ruling indicated that the charges against Paul were unjustified. The Roman government had nothing to fear from acknowledging Christianity as a legal religion.

Acts 18:17

The Greeks probably beat Sosthenes to show their anger towards the Jews. It is also possible that the Jews attacked their own synagogue leader because he failed to defend them. Sosthenes might be the same person Paul later calls "our brother" in 1 Corinthians 1:1, but this is uncertain since the name was common.

Acts 18:18

Cenchrea was a seaport on the Aegean Sea, about eight kilometers (five miles) east of Corinth. Here, Paul had his head shaved following Jewish custom to mark the completion of a temporary Nazirite vow (compare 21:23–24; and Numbers 6:1–21; Judges 13:4–7; 16:1; Amos 2:11–12; Luke 1:15).

Acts 18:19–23

Paul made a quick stop at Ephesus, the most important city in the Roman province of Asia. There he left the others behind, including Priscilla and Aquila (see 18:26).

He sailed to Judea, landing at Caesarea, the headquarters of the Roman forces of occupation. After a visit to the church at Jerusalem, Paul returned to Antioch, the church that had originally commissioned him. This marked the end of his second missionary journey.

In Antioch, he spent valuable time reporting what God had done through him and those who ministered with him. He shared the excitement and challenges of their work with the home church.

After some time, Paul began his third mission journey. He traveled by land through Galatia and Phrygia, again visiting Christians he had led to faith in Christ on his previous trips. It was important to him that these new believers did not lose their way or abandon their faith (see Ephesians 6:10–20; 1 Timothy 1:18–20; 2 Timothy 1:15; 4:10).

Acts 18:21

"I will come back to you": Paul spent a lot of time in Ephesus during his third mission journey (19:1–20:1; see 19:8, 10).

Acts 18:23

Paul wanted to remain connected with earlier converts and strengthen their faith.

Acts 18:23–19.41

This section describes Paul's third mission journey, which happened around AD 53 to 57. Paul visited Galatia and Phrygia again to build stronger relationships with the disciples (18:23). He then traveled to Ephesus, where he stayed for more than two years (19:1, 8–10).

Acts 18:24–26

Alexandria was the second-largest city in the Roman Empire. It was known for its strong tradition of public speaking and for the writings of Philo, a Jewish philosopher.

Apollos was a skilled speaker and knew the Scriptures (the Old Testament) very well. However, his understanding of Jesus and the Holy Spirit was incomplete.

He did not yet understand that believers can experience the Holy Spirit's power in their lives now.

Priscilla and Aquila kindly took him aside and explained the way of God more accurately.

Acts 19:1–7

- Paul traveled to Ephesus after Apollos had left. Later, Apollos returned to Ephesus while Paul was still there (1 Corinthians 16:12). The two men had different personalities, gifts, and roles, but God worked through both of them.
- Some Christians in Ephesus did not fully understand the Christian faith (Acts 18:26). They did not receive the Holy Spirit when they believed the good news about Jesus. They had accepted John's baptism, which called for repentance from sin, but had not received Christian baptism, which included the gift of the Holy Spirit. When Paul had instructed them further, they were able to receive Christian baptism and the Holy Spirit (19:5, 6).

Acts 19:6

When Paul laid his hands on them, they received the Holy Spirit. They spoke in other tongues (languages given by the Spirit) and prophesied (spoke messages from God). In this way, they experienced the same filling with God's power and presence that the disciples received on the day of Pentecost (2:4, 11).

Acts 19:10

Paul probably wrote 1 Corinthians during this time (see 1 Corinthians Book Introduction, "Date and Occasion of Writing").

Acts 19:11–12

- Paul, like other Christian messengers who preached the good news, performed unusual miracles (3:1–11; 4:22; 5:12–16; 6:8; 8:6–7, 13; 9:33–42).
- evil spirits left them: Evil spirits were driven out, just as Jesus and Peter had done before (compare 5:16; Mark 1:21–34; Luke 4:31–37).

Acts 19:13–16

Paul's ministry was effective, but the traveling Jewish exorcists (people who try to drive out evil spirits) had no real power. They used the name of Jesus as if it were a magic word. However, they did not have a personal relationship with him or the indwelling Holy Spirit (God's Spirit living in believers).

This contrast shows the difference between true faith and empty practice (compare Matthew 12:27; Mark 9:38–39; Luke 9:49–50; 11:19).

Acts 19:17–19

The people of Ephesus, both Jews and Greeks, noticed the difference between Paul and the Jewish exorcists. This realization caused them to honor and respect the name of the Lord Jesus. Many people confessed and gave up their sinful practices, including magic.

Acts 19:20

Luke's summary of the success of the gospel in Ephesus is short but powerful (compare 2:43–47; 5:14; 6:7; 9:31; 12:24; 16:5; and Romans 1:16). When the Christian faith overcame problems inside the church, such as division, idolatry (worship of false gods), and pagan practices (religious customs not centered on the true God), it spread widely and grew quickly.

Acts 19:21–22

- Paul resolved in the Spirit: He was probably troubled by what he heard about Corinth (see 1 Corinthians Book Introduction). Instead of going right away, he sent Timothy. Timothy carried a letter, 1 Corinthians, from Paul to the Corinthians (1 Corinthians 4:17; 16:10–11). Paul later traveled to Macedonia and Achaia (Acts 20:1–3).
- "I must see Rome as well": Paul, perhaps inspired by his successful strategy, wanted to share the gospel in the world's most important city (see study note on 16:8).

Acts 19:23

the Way: See study note on 9:2.

Acts 19:23–41

The main god worshiped in Ephesus was the Greek goddess Artemis. People believed she was born there, so the city of Ephesus was known as the guardian of her temple.

Each year, the people held large festivals in her honor. These included sports, music, and theater. During these events, people would shout, "Great is Artemis of the Ephesians!"

The temple of Artemis in Ephesus was one of the seven wonders of the ancient world.

As more people became Christians, the worship of Artemis began to decline. This also affected the local economy, since many people earned money from her

temple. However, it became clear that Paul and his coworkers had not committed any crime.

Acts 19:24

People in Ephesus made silver coins and small shrines with the image of Artemis. Small statues of the goddess were carried in city processions and are still sold there today.

Acts 19:24–34

Demetrius, a silversmith whose business was harmed by Paul's message about one God, stirred up a large riot against him.

Acts 19:27

the whole world: The ancient geographer Strabo reports that temples dedicated to Artemis existed in cities from Asia Minor (now Turkey) to what is now France and Spain (Strabo, Geography 3.4.8; 4.1.4).

Acts 19:29

Archaeologists have uncovered the amphitheater where the whole city gathered. It could hold about 24,000 people.

Acts 19:31

officials of the province of Asia: These officials, called Asiarchs ("rulers of Asia"), were the appointed leaders in the Roman province of Asia. They served as financial supporters of the city and often supported the worship of the emperor. Some of these high-ranking officials were friends of Paul. Luke shows that the Christian faith also attracted people of high social status.

Acts 19:35

The tradition said that the image (statue) of Artemis had fallen from heaven. This may mean that it was made from a meteor (a rock that falls to earth from space).

Acts 19:35–41

The city clerk stopped the demonstration to prevent the city from being accused of rioting by the Roman government. This story shows that Christians in the Roman world had the right to a fair legal process.

Acts 20:1–2

Paul traveled to Macedonia, where he encouraged Christians in towns like Thessalonica, Philippi, and Berea. He also continued collecting donations for needy Christians in Jerusalem (see Romans 15:25–28; 2 Corinthians 8:1–9:15).

Titus met Paul in Macedonia with news from Corinth, prompting Paul to write 2 Corinthians and send Titus back with the letter (2 Corinthians 7:5–7; 8:6).

Acts 20:2–3

- Paul traveled from Macedonia to Greece, specifically Corinth in Achaia, where he stayed for three months (see study note on 18:1 and 2 Corinthians 13:1). During this time, Paul probably wrote his letter to the Romans (see Romans Book Introduction, "Date, Place, and Occasion of Writing").
- a plot against him: See Acts 9:23–25, 28–30; 23:12–35; 25:3.

Acts 20:4

Paul's travel companions were disciples from Berea, Thessalonica, Derbe, and Asia. He was teaching and preparing them to lead (compare 2 Timothy 2:2).

Acts 20:5–15

This is another of the "we" passages in Acts (sections where Luke includes himself in the story; see study note on 16:10). Luke likely joined Paul again at Philippi, where he had stayed some years earlier. He then traveled with Paul to Jerusalem (21:1–18).

Acts 20:7–12

- On the first day of the week, the early church remembered the resurrection of Jesus (see Mark 16:9; compare John 20:19; Revelation 1:10).
- This was Paul's last visit to Troas. The believers met to share the Lord's Supper (a meal that remembers Jesus's death). This likely included both the bread and cup (communion) and a shared meal (compare Acts 2:42, 46; Jude 1:12).
- One notable part of this gathering was the quiet miracle involving Eutychus. He was a young man who fell asleep while sitting in a window. He fell three stories and died. Paul went down, bent over him, and took him in his arms. Then Eutychus was restored to life (God brought him back to life through Paul; compare Acts 9:36–41).

Acts 20:13–15

- Assos was an important city in Mysia on the east coast of the Aegean Sea.
- Mitylene was the most strategic city on the island of Lesbos.

- The island of Samos was crucial for trade routes from Asia Minor to the west and from the Aegean Sea to Egypt.

Acts 20:16

The Feast of Pentecost was one of the three Jewish feasts that required Jewish men to travel to Jerusalem and worship (see study note on 2:1–4).

Acts 20:17

Miletus was a major sea port on the western coast of Asia Minor at the opening of the Meander River. Paul met briefly with the elders of the church of Ephesus there on his way to Jerusalem.

Acts 20:18–38

Paul's message to the elders (leaders) of the church in Ephesus describes his life and work among them. He also calls these leaders to show the same kind of commitment as they continue the ministry.

In this message, Paul points to his own life as an example. He shows his honesty and care for people (20:18–21, 26, 31). He also speaks about what will happen in the future (20:22–23, 25, 29–30). He warns them about false teachers (people who teach wrong ideas about God; 20:29–30). And he urges the elders to stay alert and faithful (20:28, 31).

Through his example, Paul shows what it means to lead as a servant, with sacrifice and careful attention.

Acts 20:23

the Holy Spirit warns me: See, for example, 21:10–12.

Acts 20:26

Therefore I testify to you this day that I am innocent of the blood of all men: Compare Ezekiel 3:16–21.

Acts 20:28

- Paul describes the church as God's people and God's flock (a group cared for by a shepherd; compare 1 Peter 2:25; 5:2, 4). In other places, the church is described as:
- "the body of Christ" (1 Corinthians 12:27; Ephesians 1:23; 4:12; Colossians 1:24);
- the "bride" of Christ (2 Corinthians 11:2; Revelation 19:7; see Ephesians 5:25–32;
- "God's temple" (1 Corinthians 3:16; 2 Corinthians 6:16).
- "a chosen people, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people for God's own possession" (1 Peter 2:9); and
- "God's field, God's building" (1 Corinthians 3:9).
- Paul expected the leaders to care for and guide the church, like shepherds care for their flock. The Holy Spirit had appointed them to this role (see 1 Timothy 3:1–7; Titus 1:5–7; 1 Peter 5:1–4; compare Acts 6:2–4).

Acts 20:29–30

savage wolves: Paul's prophecy did in fact happen, prompting him to write to Timothy in Ephesus some five years later (see 1 Timothy 1:3–7, 19–20; 4:1–5; see also Matthew 7:15; 10:16; Mark 13:22; Luke 10:3; 2 Peter 2:1–22; 3:3).

Acts 20:35

'It is more blessed to give than to receive': This saying of Jesus does not appear in the Gospels.

Acts 20:38

The occasion felt more emotional because the church at Ephesus knew they would never see Paul again (20:25).

Acts 21:1

- Cos was an island in the Aegean Sea with a major trade port.
- Rhodes is a large Aegean island. The Colossus, a huge statue 30 meters (100 feet) tall, once stood at the city's entrance. In Paul's time, the statue lay where it had fallen during an earthquake over 200 years earlier. It would remain there for another 600 years.
- Patara was the main port of Lycia, located on the coast across from Rhodes.

Acts 21:1–18

This "we" passage (see study notes on 16:10; 20:5–15) covers Paul's journey from Miletus to Jerusalem at the close of the third missionary journey.

Acts 21:2–3

Tyre was an important port in Phoenicia with an empire centered on sea activity and widespread trade interests (see Isaiah 23; Jeremiah 25:15–38; 47; Zechariah 9; Matthew 15:21–28; Mark 7:24–31).

Acts 21:4–6

- The disciples in Tyre gave Paul a warm and emotional farewell. This shows the deep fellowship (shared life and unity) among Christians.

- Through the Spirit they kept telling Paul not to go up to Jerusalem: The disciples in Tyre clearly understood the danger he would face there. Because they cared for him, they tried to persuade him not to go.

However, Paul accepted these risks. He chose to go in order to complete the mission God had given him (compare Philippians 3:7–10). See also study note on Acts 21:11–14.

Acts 21:7

Paul visited Ptolemais, an important city on the coast of the Mediterranean, as he made his way from Tyre to Caesarea.

Acts 21:8

Philip was called an evangelist (someone who shares the good news about Jesus) because of his work in preaching the gospel (see 8:4–40; compare Ephesians 4:11; 2 Timothy 4:5).

Acts 21:9

Philip's daughters had the gift of prophecy (the ability to speak messages from God). This showed that Joel's prophecy (Joel 2:28–32) had been fulfilled, just as Peter had said at Pentecost (2:17–21).

Acts 21:10

Luke places female prophets (21:9) alongside a male prophet (see study note on 17:34). This shows that both women and men were used by God to speak his message in the early church.

Agabus, like the Old Testament prophets (God's messengers before the time of Jesus), used symbolic actions (visible actions that show a message) to communicate what God had revealed to him (see "Prophetic Sign Acts" Theme Note).

Acts 21:11–14

Despite Agabus's prediction of suffering and the believers' begging Paul not to go to Jerusalem, Paul was ready even to die for the sake of the Lord Jesus. Luke emphasizes Paul's courage, determination, and heroism as a Christian missionary who would let nothing interfere with his mission. See study note on 21:4–6.

Acts 21:18–19

It was important for James and all the elders (leaders) of the church in Jerusalem to hear about Paul's successful work among the Gentiles. It was also important for the Jerusalem church, the first main church, to continue to support this mission (21:20; see 15:7–21). Paul's report showed that God had carried out his plan among the Gentiles through Paul's work.

Acts 21:20–25

The leaders of the Jerusalem church urged Paul to strengthen his credibility. They encouraged him to demonstrate that he was not teaching Jews to abandon the laws of Moses. Meanwhile, the leaders did not force Jewish rules on Gentile converts. They had determined these terms earlier and would respect them (15:22–29).

Acts 21:26–36

The concerns of the Christian leaders were well-founded (21:20–25). When Paul and the other men had almost completed their vow, some Jews from Asia falsely accused Paul and raised a mob against him. They intended to kill Paul, but the Roman commander rescued him.

Acts 21:28–29

Greeks: It was a crime punishable by death to bring Gentiles (non-Jewish people) into the inner areas of the temple, beyond the Court of the Gentiles (see also Josephus, War 5.5.2; 6.2.4). The Jews believed Paul broke this holy law by bringing Trophimus, a Gentile from Ephesus, into the area reserved for only Jews (see also Acts 20:4; 2 Timothy 4:20).

Acts 21:30

This supposed defilement of the temple made many of the Jews very angry. They believed the temple had been made unclean by a Greek (non-Jew), so they quickly shut the temple gates.

Acts 21:31

commander: Or tribune, a Roman officer who commanded 1,000 men.

Acts 21:34

Herod the Great built the Antonia Fortress, a large military base, on the northwest corner of the Temple Mount. It housed the Roman soldiers stationed there to keep the peace.

Acts 21:37–40

The commander had mistaken Paul for an Egyptian false messiah who had planned to seize power from the Romans around AD 54 (roughly three years earlier; see Josephus, War 2.13.5). Paul corrected the mistake, gained permission to speak to the people, and addressed the crowd in Aramaic, the common language

of Judea. He gave a strong statement of his faith in Jesus as the Messiah (Acts 22:1–21).

Acts 22:1–21

Paul gives his most complete defense of his life and faith before his own people in Jerusalem. This speech shows his flexibility as a missionary, just as his message to the Greek philosophers in Athens also did (17:22–31; see 1 Corinthians 9:20–23).

He begins by showing his close connection with his audience. He explains his Jewish background and his training under Gamaliel the Elder (a respected Jewish teacher). He also describes his strong desire to honor God, a desire they shared (Acts 22:1–3).

Paul then recounts how he once persecuted Christians (22:4–5). He tells about seeing Jesus on the road to Damascus (22:6–10). and explains his conversion (his turning to follow Jesus; 22:11–16).

He ends by describing a vision in the temple, where the Lord spoke to him. The Lord told him that many Jews would reject the message and that he should go to the Gentiles (22:17–21).

Acts 22:3

at the feet of Gamaliel: See study note on 5:34.

Acts 22:12–16

Ananias: See study note on 9:17.

Acts 22:14

the Righteous One: See also 3:14; 7:52; 1 John 2:1. Righteousness was a key characteristic of the Messiah (see Isaiah 32:1; 53:11).

Acts 22:16

be baptized, and wash your sins away: See "Baptism" Theme Note.

Acts 22:17–22

While Paul was praying in the temple, he saw a vision of Jesus. Jesus told him that the people of Jerusalem would not accept his message. The Lord then sent him to the Gentiles. The crowd's reaction to this report confirmed this reality (22:22–23).

Acts 22:23

The crowd shouted, threw off their coats, and tossed dust into the air. These actions were likely ritual responses to what they thought was blasphemy (speech that dishonors God). They strongly opposed Paul's message, especially his claim that Gentiles were included among God's people (22:21). Compare with Luke 4:16–30.

Acts 22:25–29

Paul asserted his Roman citizenship at a crucial moment when he encountered torture to make him confess a supposed crime. Roman citizenship was valuable. Claiming it falsely was a capital offense. Its main benefits included protection from whipping and the right to appeal to the emperor (25:11). The commander was afraid because he had almost violated Roman law (compare 16:35–39).

Acts 22:28

I paid a high price: During the early rule of Roman emperor Claudius (AD 41–54), people could buy Roman citizenship, but it was expensive.

Acts 23:1

When speaking to the Jewish high council (the Sanhedrin), Paul said he had lived with a clear conscience before God. He had not broken God's law or done what they accused him of doing.

Acts 23:2

- Ananias was the Jewish high priest from AD 47 to 58.
- strike him: Ananias had the apostle struck because he thought Paul was lying and wanted to scare him.

Acts 23:3

you whitewashed wall: Compare Ezekiel 13:10–17; Matthew 23:27.

Acts 23:5

- It is unclear why Paul did not recognize the high priest.
- Paul responded by quoting Exodus 22:28, showing respect for the high priest's position.

Acts 23:6

Paul focused on the main issue in his trial: the hope of the resurrection (the belief that the dead will be raised to life). His preaching came from this hope and from the fact that Jesus had risen from the dead.

However, his message was not accepted by either group of Jews because of what it meant. The Pharisees believed in the resurrection, but they could not accept that Gentiles could be included among God's people without circumcision and without keeping the law of Moses (see 15:5). Yet this is exactly what the resurrec-

tion of Jesus and the gift of the Holy Spirit had made possible (see Acts 2:39; 10:34–48).

The Sadducees, on the other hand, did not believe in the resurrection at all. Because of this, they strongly opposed any teaching about the resurrection (see 4:1–2).

Acts 23:7–10

Paul's statement divided the Sanhedrin (23:6). The Pharisees supported Paul against the Sadducees. The disagreement was so intense that the commander rescued Paul and took him back to the fortress of Antonia.

Acts 23:11

At this important moment, Jesus encouraged Paul to continue as his faithful witness by assuring him that he would go to Rome (see 19:21).

Acts 23:12–15

The plan to kill Paul was desperate. More than 40 men took an oath (a strong promise) not to eat or drink until they had killed him (compare 1 Samuel 14:24–46; Matthew 14:6–11; see also Deuteronomy 23:21–23; Matthew 5:33–37; James 5:12).

Acts 23:16–22

Paul's nephew stopped the plan to kill him by telling a Roman officer.

Acts 23:23–35

A large group riding horses safely brought Paul to the Roman governor Felix in Caesarea, the Roman headquarters for Judea. Paul would have more protection there than in Jerusalem. The soldiers carried out the mission that night with great care and secrecy (23:31).

Acts 23:24

Antonius Felix was the governor of Judea from about AD 52 to 59. He was in charge of both military and civil matters. Felix had a bad reputation and was eventually called back to Rome by Emperor Nero (see 24:24–27).

Acts 23:26–30

- The letter from Claudius Lysias to Governor Felix follows the common form of a Hellenistic letter (a standard Greek-style letter used in that time). It names the writer and the recipient, gives a greeting, and explains the main issue. However, it does not include a closing farewell (see study note on 15:29). The letter also summarizes the events leading up to it and explains the actions taken. It shows that the commander believed he had followed proper Roman legal procedures.
- His Excellency: This title was often used for people with high social, political, or economic status (Luke 1:3).

Acts 23:31

Antipatris was a city rebuilt by Herod the Great in 9 BC on the Plain of Sharon. It served as a strategic military control point between Jerusalem and Caesarea.

Acts 23:35

- The governor followed the correct steps and waited for Paul's accusers to arrive before having an official legal hearing.
- Herod's Praetorium: Herod's headquarters was the palace built by Herod the Great in Caesarea. Later, this palace became the residence (official home) of the Roman governors of Judea.

Acts 24:1–4

Tertullus presented the case for the prosecution. He began with the usual words of praise to gain the governor's attention and favor. Then he listed the charges against Paul (24:5–8).

Acts 24:1–27

Tertullus presented a legal case against Paul in a Roman court on behalf of the high priest (24:1–9). Then Paul cheerfully defended himself and his faith (24:10–21). The governor paused the hearing without making a decision. He kept Paul in prison for two years (24:22–27).

Acts 24:5

- a pestilence, stirring up dissension among the Jews all over the world: A Roman court would have taken this charge very seriously. This language presents him as someone who causes unrest. It reflects a charge of political sedition (acting against the state), which a Roman court would have treated as a serious crime (see 16:21; 17:7; 18:13). People made similar accusations against Jesus to Pontius Pilate (Luke 23:2, 5, 14).
- sect: This term is used here in a negative way. It suggests that Paul's faith was suspicious or even unlawful (see also Acts 24:14).

Acts 24:6

desecrate the temple: See study note on 21:28–29.

Acts 24:10–21

Paul defended himself by saying:

1. he was not in Jerusalem long enough to start a riot;
2. none of those who accused him saw him causing a riot; and
3. he worshiped according to Jewish law and the writings of the prophets.

Acts 24:14

- the Way: See study note on 9:2.
- Paul emphasized what he shared in common with his Jewish audience, including his worship, belief in the Jewish law, acceptance of the prophets, and hope in the resurrection (24:14, 15; see 24:21).

Acts 24:15

At the final judgment (the time when God judges all people), God will raise both the righteous (those who follow him) and the unrighteous (those who do not). Paul kept this coming meeting with God in mind at all times (24:16). Felix became afraid when Paul spoke about "the coming judgment" in a later conversation (24:25).

Acts 24:16

Paul emphasized that he had acted with a clear conscience (see 20:27, 33; 23:1; 1 Corinthians 4:4; 2 Corinthians 1:12; 4:2; see also 2 Timothy 1:3). He remained true to his Jewish heritage and did not fear God's judgment (Acts 24:14, 15).

Acts 24:17

- alms to my people: See study note on 20:1–2; also see Romans 15:25–29; 1 Corinthians 16:1–2; 2 Corinthians 9:1–7.
- to present offerings: See Acts 21:23–26.

Acts 24:22

The governor Felix might have delayed his decision, hoping Paul would offer him a bribe (24:26).

Acts 24:23

Proper treatment of a Roman citizen involved giving him some freedom and allowing his friends to visit and care for him.

Acts 24:24

Drusilla was the sister of Herod Agrippa II and Bernice (25:13). She left her first husband, Azizus, the King of Emessa, to marry Felix. Drusilla was Jewish, so by leaving her original husband and marrying Felix, she violated God's commands (Exodus 20:14; Deuteronomy 5:18; compare Malachi 2:16; Mark 10:12). The Jewish historian Josephus criticized her for doing this (Antiquities 20.7.1–2). During their conversation with Paul, Drusilla and her husband were faced with the reality of God's judgment (his just decision about human actions).

Acts 24:25

Paul's words about righteousness, self-control, and the coming judgment scared Felix, who was notably corrupt (24:26–27; see study notes on 23:24; 24:24).

Acts 24:26–27

Felix kept Paul in custody, hoping that Paul would offer him a bribe. When this did not work and his term as governor ended, he left Paul in prison to please the Jewish people.

Acts 24:27–25.5

Felix's successor was Porcius Festus. Nero appointed him as governor of Judea around AD 59–62. Josephus describes Festus as a careful and honest leader. However, he could not stop the growing unrest among the Jewish people, even though he took strong action against the Assassins (a violent group also called the Sicarii; Josephus, Antiquities 20.8.10; see also Acts 21:38).

Festus refused the Jewish leaders' request to move Paul's trial to Jerusalem, but he still felt their pressure (25:9).

Acts 25:7

The serious accusations were likely the ones mentioned earlier (21:27–28; 24:5–9). But there was no evidence to support them (24:10–13).

Acts 25:9

Festus, wishing to do the Jews a favor: The governor later gave an official reason for delaying Paul's trial and asking to move it to Jerusalem (25:17–20). However, politics, not justice, motivated his request.

Acts 25:10–11

Festus suggested that Paul have his trial in Jerusalem, which led Paul to appeal to Caesar. Paul did not fear death, but he opposed being transferred to a court biased toward condemnation, not justice (25:7).

Acts 25:12

Festus approved Paul's request. This confirmed Paul's belief that he must visit Rome (19:21; see also 23:11; 27:24; Romans 1:13–15; 15:22–29).

Acts 25:13–22

Festus discussed Paul's case with Herod Agrippa II, who came to Caesarea to pay a courtesy visit to the new governor. Herod Agrippa II ruled parts of the region from AD 50–100.

Acts 25:16

This was a fundamental principle: Roman law did not convict people without a trial. They must be given an opportunity to confront their accusers and defend themselves (see 19:38–39). This showed Roman legal procedures in a positive way.

Acts 25:17

I did not delay: This is different from Felix, the previous governor, who delayed making a decision (24:22–27).

Acts 25:18–20

These verses provide the official reasons Festus gave for his actions (see also 25:9). There were no criminal charges against Paul. The objections were about their religion and focused on Paul's claim that Jesus is alive.

Acts 25:23–27

Paul's legal hearing before King Agrippa included all the ceremony of a royal visit. The main purpose was for Agrippa to advise Festus on what to write in the appeal to Caesar. There was no clear charge against Paul. Festus believed Paul had done nothing deserving death.

Acts 26:1–23

In his careful defense before King Agrippa, Paul argued that his message agreed fully with the Jewish faith. He began by respectfully recognizing Agrippa's knowledge of Jewish matters (26:2–3). He then described his early life, his training in Judaism, and his membership in the Pharisees (a Jewish group known for strict obedience to the law; 26:4–5).

Paul explained that the charges against him were only because he believed that God had fulfilled the Jewish hope of the resurrection (God raising the dead to life; 26:6–8).

He then told how he had once strongly opposed Christians (26:9–11), but changed after seeing a vision from Jesus on the road to Damascus (26:12–18; see 9:1–18).

Paul said that his preaching simply obeyed this message from God (26:19–20). Although some Jews opposed him violently (26:21), God protected him. He continued to teach a message that his fellow Jews should have accepted (22–23). This defense shows an example for Christians who are put on trial for their faith (see 9:15; Luke 21:12–15).

Acts 26:12–18

See 9:1–18.

Acts 26:17–18

Throughout his defense in this trial for his life, Paul also clearly set out the conditions for receiving new life in Christ (also in 26:20, 23; see Matthew 10:19–20).

Acts 26:22–23

Paul stressed that God protected him as he carried out his witness (compare 3:18; 10:43; Luke 24:25–27, 44–47). Paul urged his listeners to believe that Jesus is the Christ who fulfills Old Testament promises (see Luke 24:27, 44).

Acts 26:24

You are insane, Paul!: Festus, a Roman, thought Paul's talk about the prophets and resurrection was crazy (compare 17:18, 32). He concluded that Paul had studied so much it drove him to madness.

Acts 26:26

it was not done in a corner: The main events of the Christian faith were public historical events. Witnesses could confirm them as true. King Agrippa could not contradict Paul's statements of fact.

Acts 26:27–28

Paul's question put King Agrippa in a difficult position. If Agrippa said he believed the prophets, Paul would press the Christian message. If Agrippa denied belief in the prophets, he would upset the devout Jews who were listening.

Agrippa knew Paul was not crazy and that Paul's testimony about Jesus was historically accurate (26:26). So, Agrippa avoided answering Paul's question and refused to consider the claims of Christ. Agrippa said that Paul's statement was too short for him to make a responsible decision.

Acts 26:28

"Can you persuade me in such a short time to become a Christian?": This remark might have been ironic,

expressing a lack of belief. It might have been making fun of Paul, or a dismissal of Paul's challenge. It might also have been a comment on how well Paul could persuade. Or it could have been a genuine question about Paul's intention. It seems best to understand King Agrippa's reply as intentionally trying to avoid the question. He did not want to admit he believed the prophets, because Paul had made a strong case (26:27).

The next step would be to believe in Jesus as the promised Christ, which Agrippa did not want to do. On the other hand, he did not want to say he did not believe the prophets. This would cause his Jewish subjects to feel isolated, and Agrippa wanted their allegiance. His lack of a committed response emphasizes his discomfort with Paul's testimony.

Acts 26:29

Paul's bold answer shows that he could respond quickly and clearly. He challenges Agrippa and the whole audience to think about the value of knowing Christ and making a personal commitment to him.

Acts 26:31

The rulers agreed that Paul did not deserve death or imprisonment. Roman authorities repeatedly gave this verdict when considering Paul's case (25:25; see Luke 23:4, 15, 22).

Acts 26:32

Paul could have been set free because the legal verdict was evident (26:31). However, if he had not appealed to Caesar, Paul might not have survived (25:1–11). By appealing, he was fulfilling God's purposes for him (23:11).

Acts 27:1

- Julius is not known from other sources.
- the Imperial Regiment: This group of soldiers was stationed in Syria during this period (see study note on 10:1–8).

Acts 27:1–28.16

- The graphic language describing sailing in the story of Paul's journey to Rome provides one of the best accounts of an ancient sea journey.
- This is the last "we" section in Acts (see also 16:10–17; 20:5–15; 21:1–18). During Paul's two years of imprisonment, Luke probably researched his gospel throughout Judea and Galilee. Here, as part of Paul's sailing group, he had a personal witness of the dangers at sea.

Acts 27:2

- Aristarchus was from Thessalonica and worked with Paul in Asia (see 19:29; 20:4, 6; Philemon 1:24).
- Adramyttium was a seaport on the west coast of Asia Minor, southeast of Troas.

Acts 27:3

Sidon was a city on the coast, about 110 kilometers (70 miles) north of Caesarea. It was the ship's first stop. Julius (the Roman officer in charge) treated Paul kindly and allowed his Christian friends there to care for him.

Acts 27:4–6

- Luke gives a detailed description of the sea journey. The ship traveled north and then west along the southern coast of Asia Minor (modern-day Turkey).
- Myra was an important stop. Ships from Egypt carrying grain (food crops like wheat) to Italy regularly stopped there.

Acts 27:7

- The difficulty was partly because it was late in the season (27:9).
- Cnidus was a seaport on the southwestern coast of Asia Minor, near the island of Cos.
- The cape of Salmone was at the northeastern tip of Crete, the largest island in Greece.

Acts 27:8

Fair Havens is a small bay on the south side of the island of Crete.

Acts 27:9

because it was after the Fast: It was late in the fall, which meant travel on the Mediterranean Sea was dangerous.

Acts 27:10–11

Paul understood the consequences if they continued. He warned the ship's officers. But they and the Roman officer were not likely to listen to an imprisoned Jewish rabbi with no sailing experience. Later, however, they would respect him more (27:30–36, 42–43).

Acts 27:12

The winds from the southeast made Fair Havens not a safe harbor for winter. Phoenix, a town further up the coast of Crete, offered a better harbor.

Acts 27:14–16

the Northeaster: This storm had the strength of a hurricane or cyclone. It threatened both the cargo and the crew. Forced to let the ship run in front of the storm, they sailed past a small island called Cauda (known today as Gaudos), south of Crete.

Acts 27:17

- The purpose of wrapping ropes around the ship's framework (hull) was to strengthen it against the storm's pressure. This process is called frapping.
- Syrtis refers to the shallow bays with sandbars off the North African coast, west of Cyrene.

Acts 27:18–20

The violent and persistent storm forced the crew to throw the cargo over the side of the boat (compare Jonah 1:5). The crew had lost hope.

Acts 27:21–26

Paul spoke to the crew. He first criticized them for not listening to him (27:10–12). Then, he encouraged them by sharing the angel's assurance that everyone would survive.

Acts 27:27

The Adriatic Sea is also known as the Ionian Sea. It is south of Italy and Greece, between Malta and Crete.

Acts 27:30–32

This time the soldiers listened to Paul (compare 27:10–11).

Acts 27:33–35

Paul acts like a true leader. He personally evaluates a dangerous situation, decides on a plan, and guides others to solve the problem (compare Nehemiah 1–3; contrast with Jonah 1). Paul's positive example and strong faith in God encouraged the others to eat and remain hopeful (Acts 27:22–25).

Acts 27:36–37

- The food gave new strength and hope to the scared and tired crew and prisoners.
- 276 of us: This number matches what we know about ships carrying grain from that time period.

Acts 27:39–41

They guided the ship onto a sandbar (a shallow area of sand in the water).

Acts 27:42–44

Even during a crisis, the soldiers were responsible for the prisoners (see 12:19; 16:27; 27:32; see study note on 16:27). Fortunately, the commanding officer helped them. This showed God's protection and favor, as all 276 people safely reached the shore, exactly as the angel promised (see 27:24).

Acts 28:1

Malta was a large island controlled by the Romans, located about 100 kilometers (60 miles) south of Sicily.

Acts 28:3–6

The people of Malta believed that justice was a personal power or a god who punished criminals. When nothing bad happened to Paul, they changed their minds. They saw that he was not harmed by the snake. So they thought he had power over snakes and said that he must be a god (compare 14:11–12).

But this was not true. Paul did not have special power in himself. Instead, his survival showed that God was protecting him (compare Mark 16:17–18).

Acts 28:8–9

Compare with Luke 4:38–40.

Acts 28:10

Showing their gratefulness, the people supplied the ship's company with what they needed.

Acts 28:11

Another Egyptian ship from Alexandria took Paul and his companions on board after an interval of three months and the worst of the winter had passed.

Acts 28:11–16

Luke was on this journey and described Paul's route from Malta to Rome with great geographical detail (see study note on 27:1–28:16).

Acts 28:12

Syracuse was the capital of the eastern half of Sicily.

Acts 28:13–14

- They sailed across the Straits of Messina to Rhegium at the southern tip of Italy. This seaport was a stop for ships traveling from Italy's west coast to the eastern Mediterranean.
- Puteoli (modern Pozzuoli) was a major entry port for large ships bringing grain and supplies from the

east to Rome. Paul spent a week here with local Christians before continuing to Rome.

Acts 28:15

The brothers there: The Christians in that place welcomed Paul and the group as they traveled to Rome.

Acts 28:16

They allowed Paul to have private quarters, with a soldier to guard him. Even though Paul traveled in chains, "the word of God cannot be chained!" (2 Timothy 2:9). Paul was possibly treated well because of his social status or Roman citizenship (compare Acts 16:37–38; 22:25–28).

Acts 28:17–20

Paul knew that the gospel should be shared with the Jews first (13:46; Romans 1:16). He was also concerned that false charges against him might have already reached Rome. So he called together the local Jewish leaders and explained his life and work. He insisted that he had not committed any crime.

But strong opposition from other Jews had forced him to appeal to the emperor. Paul said he had nothing against his own people. Instead, he wanted to explain his deep conviction that the Messiah (God's promised king) they were waiting for had already come in Jesus of Nazareth.

Acts 28:21–22

The Jewish leaders assured Paul that they had received no reports against him, and they wanted to hear his explanation of this movement.

Acts 28:23

Paul explained how Jesus fulfilled the Old Testament hopes for the kingdom of God. This was the main theme of the preaching of Jesus (Mark 1:14–15; see Matthew 4:12–17; Luke 4:14–21, 43). Paul used the Old Testament Scriptures to show that Jesus was the promised Messiah.

Acts 28:24

Paul spoke to them all day, but the people responded in different ways, just as people had done in other places (for example, 13:40–51; 17:11–14).

Acts 28:25–28

As Paul left, he gave a warning from Scripture. These words are often used in the New Testament to explain why many Jews did not accept the good news about Jesus (compare Matthew 13:14–15; Mark 4:12; Luke 8:10; John 12:38–40; see Romans 11:1–12, 25–32).

Acts 28:28

Since Jews everywhere had the chance to accept the faith, it was now time to offer this salvation to the Gentiles (13:46; see Romans 1:16).

Acts 28:31

- Even though Paul was under house arrest, he boldly proclaimed the kingdom message (the good news about God's rule; 28:16).
- freely (Greek akōlutōs, meaning "without restriction"): This Greek word is the last word in the book of Acts and helps show its meaning. God's word cannot be chained, even when his messengers are (2 Timothy 2:9; see Philippians 1:12–14).

The book of Acts tells the story of a message of good news that extends to everyone worldwide. This includes Jews and Gentiles (non-Jews), converts to Judaism, the rich, and the poor. The mission to spread this message is done through the power of the Holy Spirit (Acts 1:8).
It reaches:

- Jews (3:1–5:42),
- Samaritans (8:1–25),
- converts to Judaism (2:11; 13:43),
- "God-fearers" (8:26–40; 9:32–11:18), and
- Gentiles (13:1–28:28).
- Luke ends his account with Paul still under house arrest in Rome (around AD 60–62). They later released Paul and he traveled again. Tradition says Paul was imprisoned again in Rome around AD 64. He died as a martyr (a witness for Christ) during Emperor Nero's persecution of Christians.